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(54) **GAMING SYSTEM AND METHOD FOR OFFERING SOCIAL MEDIA ACTIVITY IN ASSOCIATION WITH WAGERING**

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None
See application file for complete search history.

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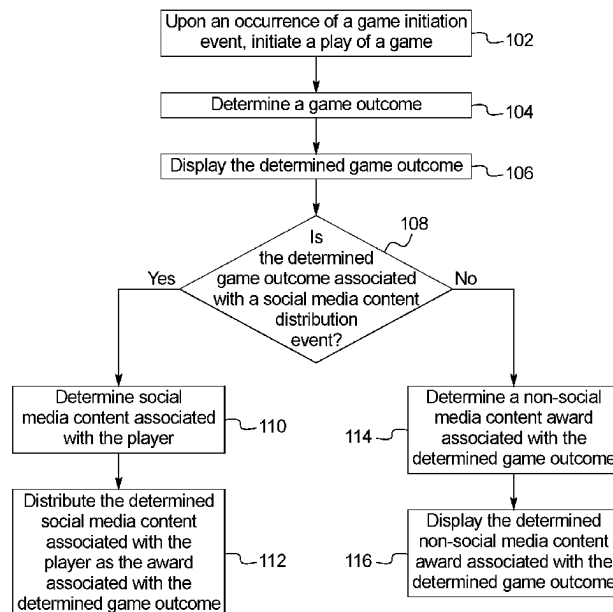
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(57) **ABSTRACT**
Gaming systems and methods that provides zero, one or more social media benefits to a player in addition to any awards provided to that player in association with a play of a game.

10 Claims, 8 Drawing Sheets



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FIG. 1

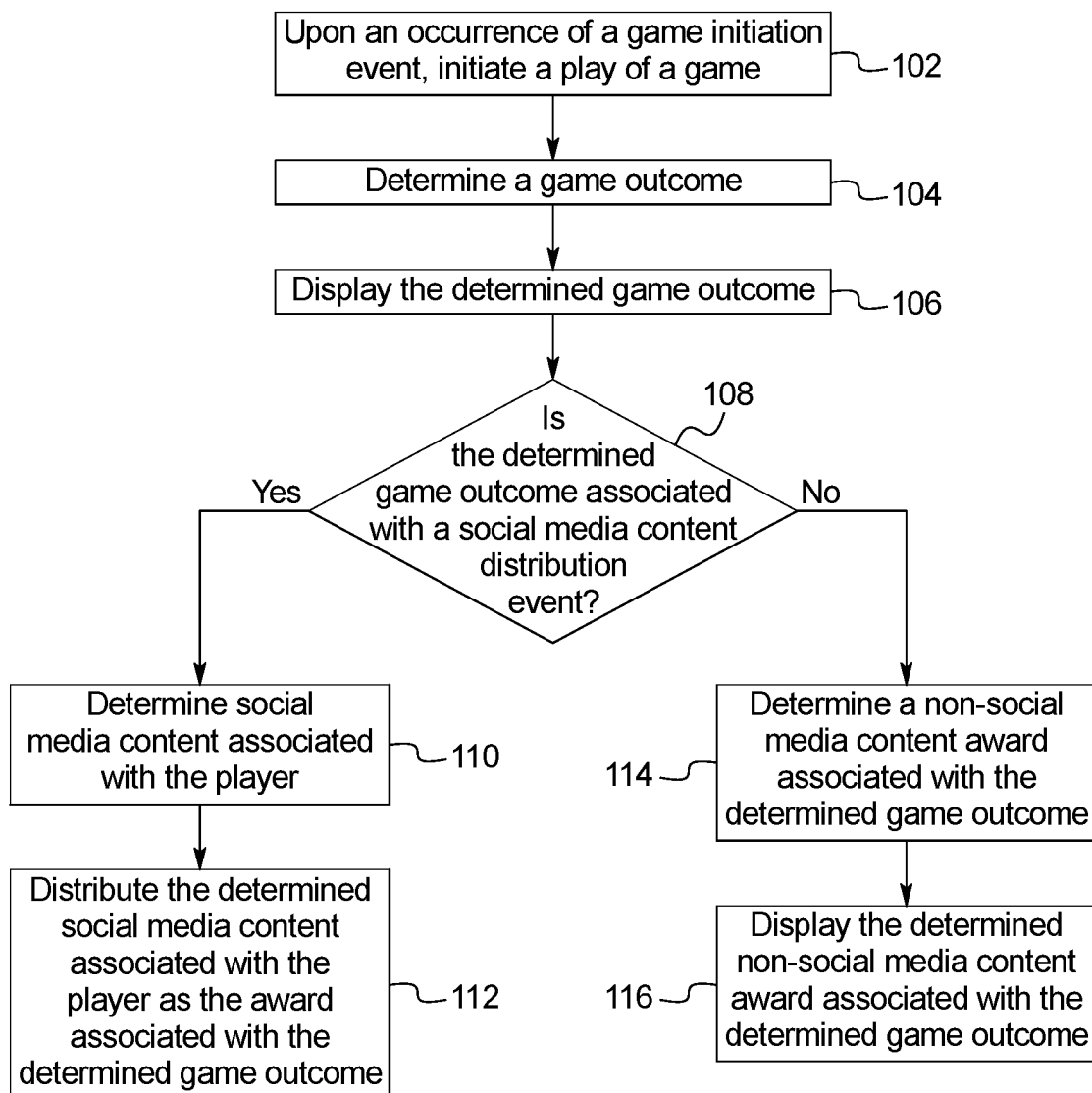


FIG. 2A

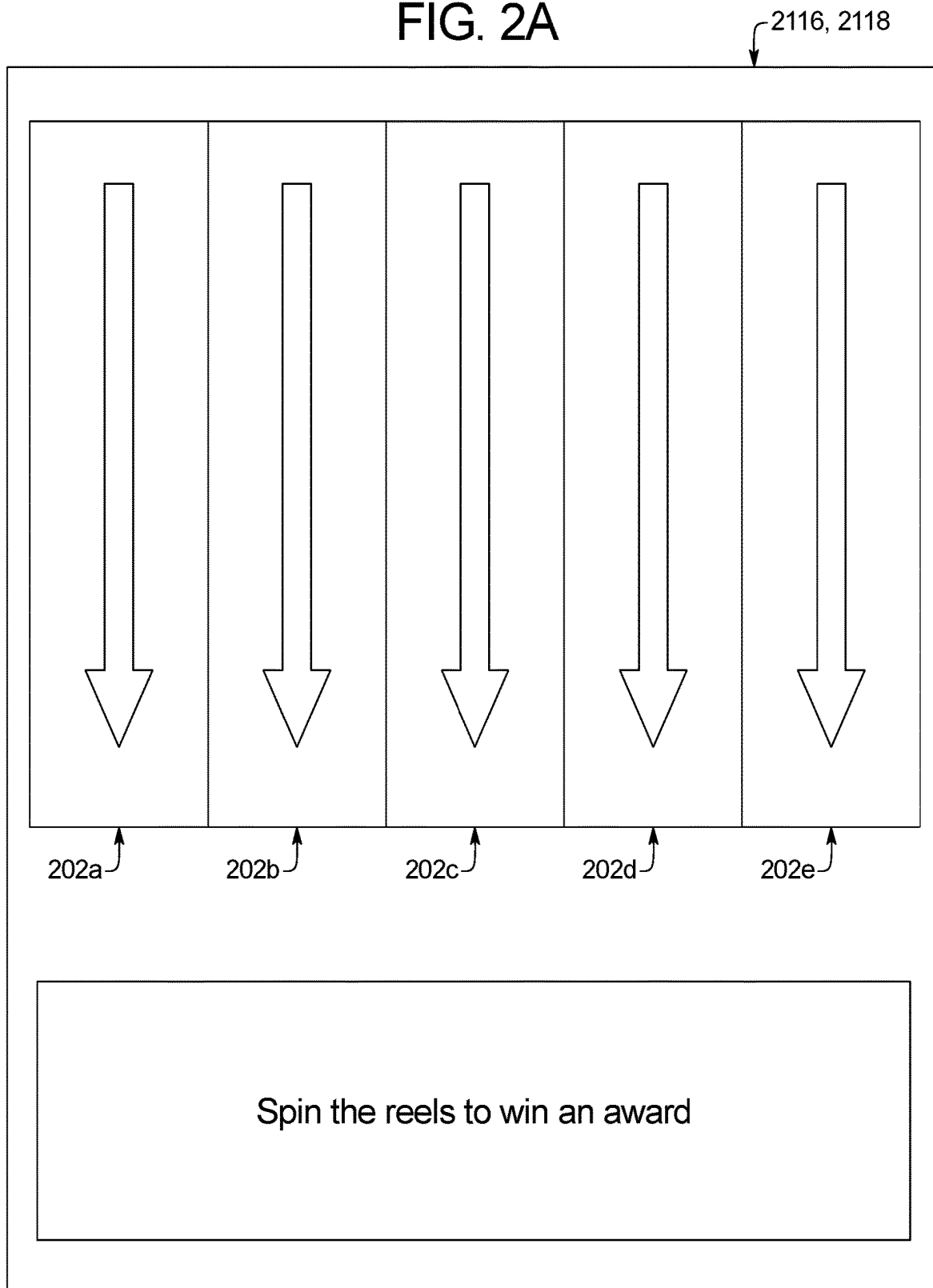


FIG. 2B

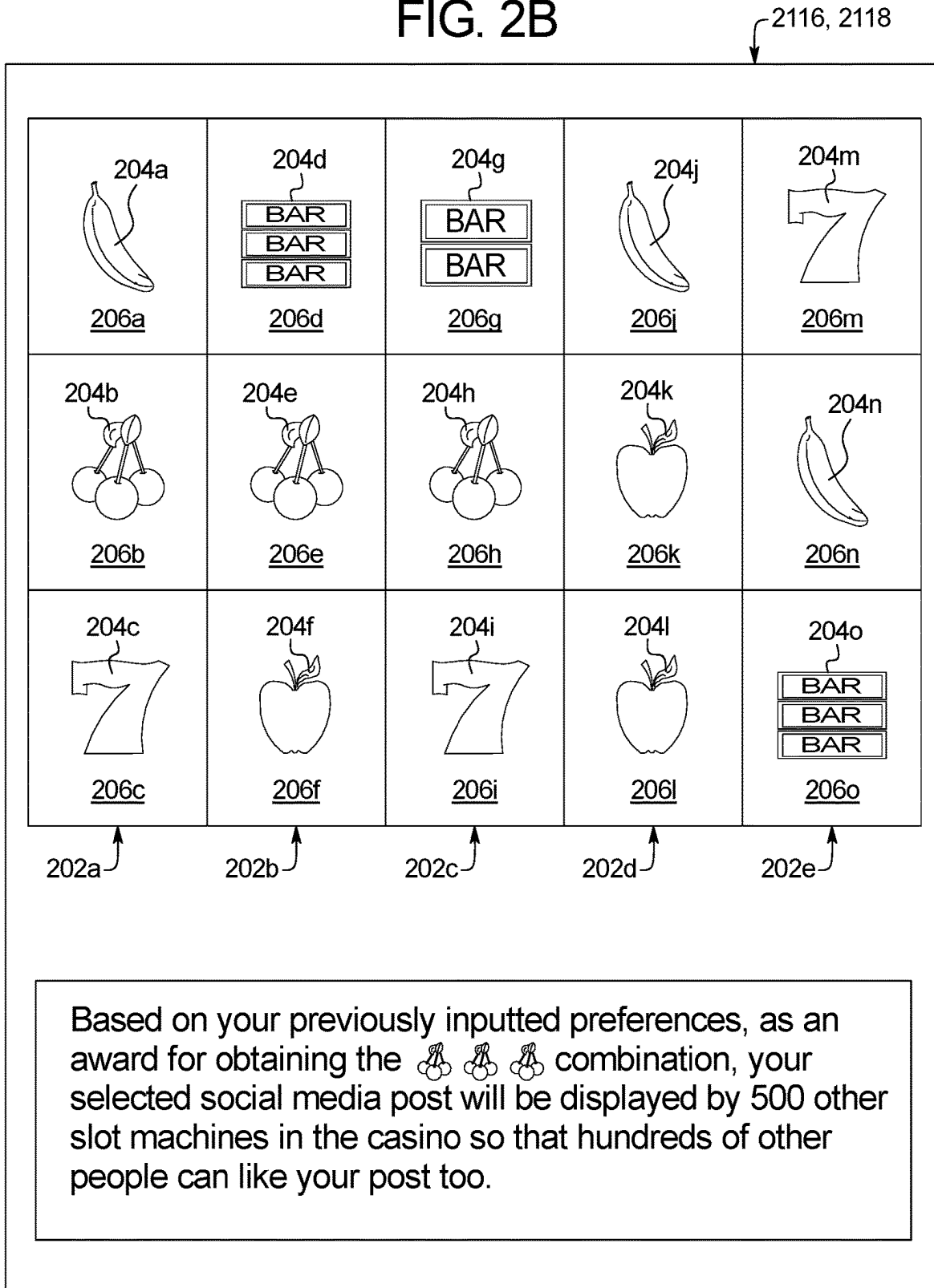
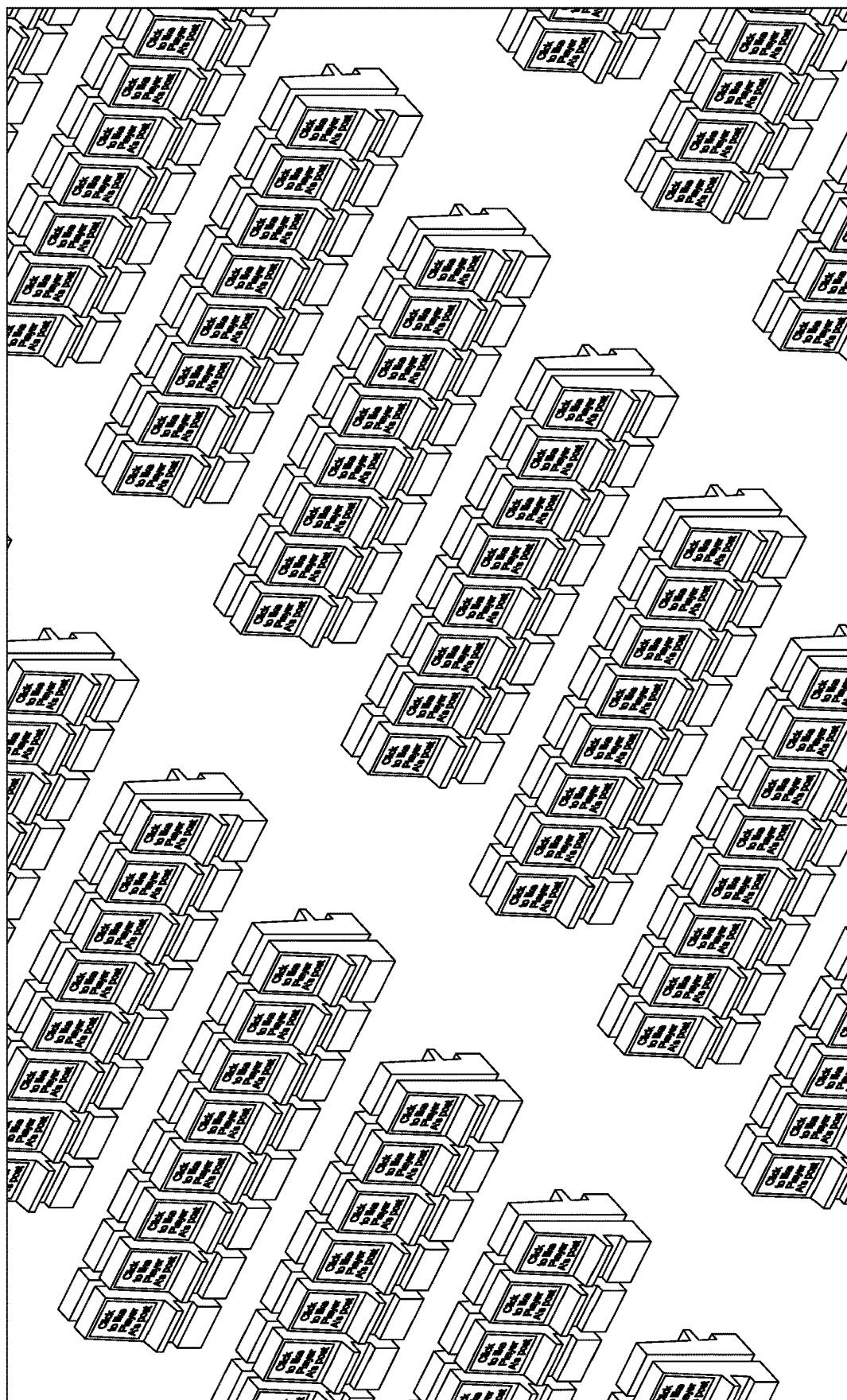


FIG. 2C



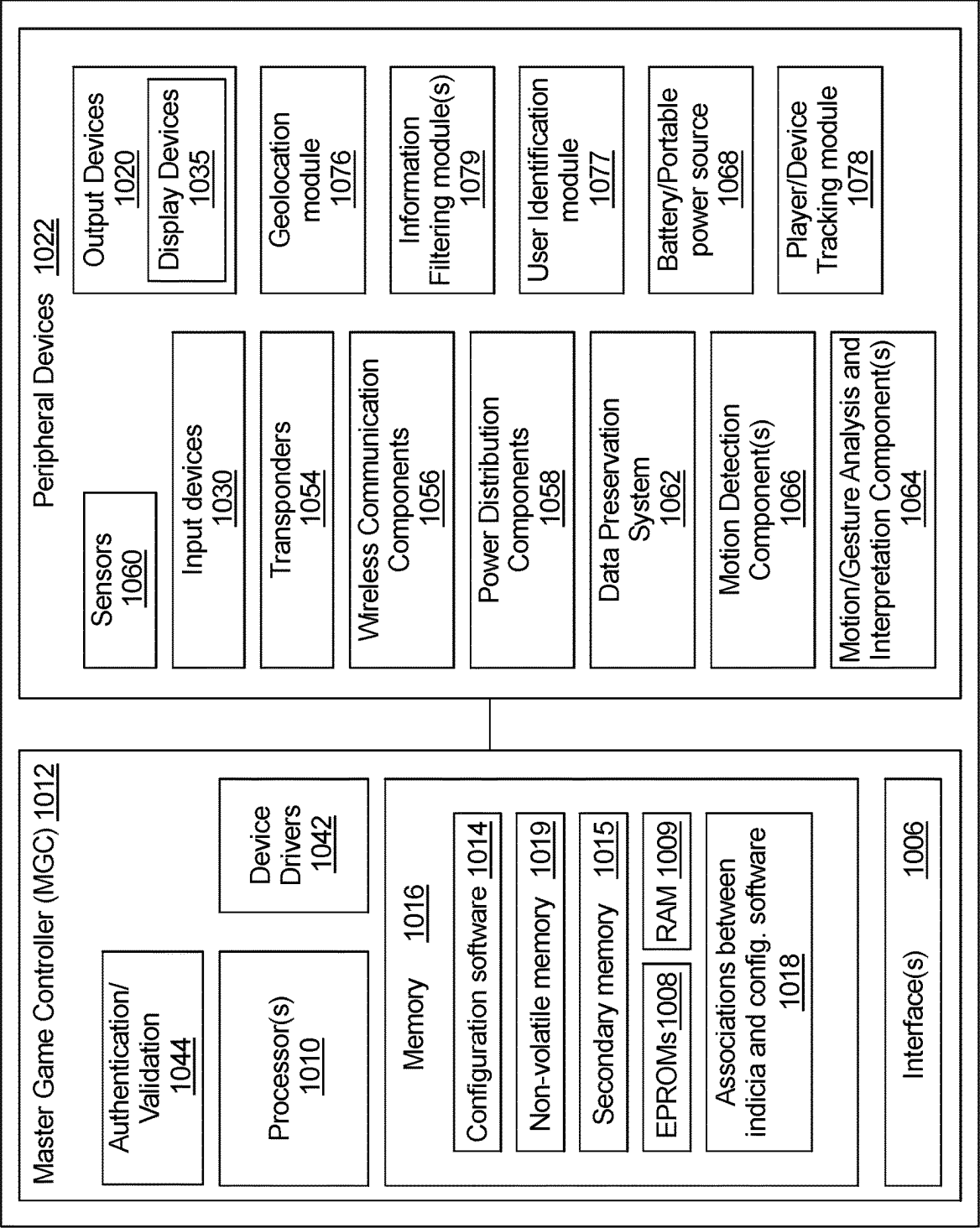


FIG. 3

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FIG. 4A

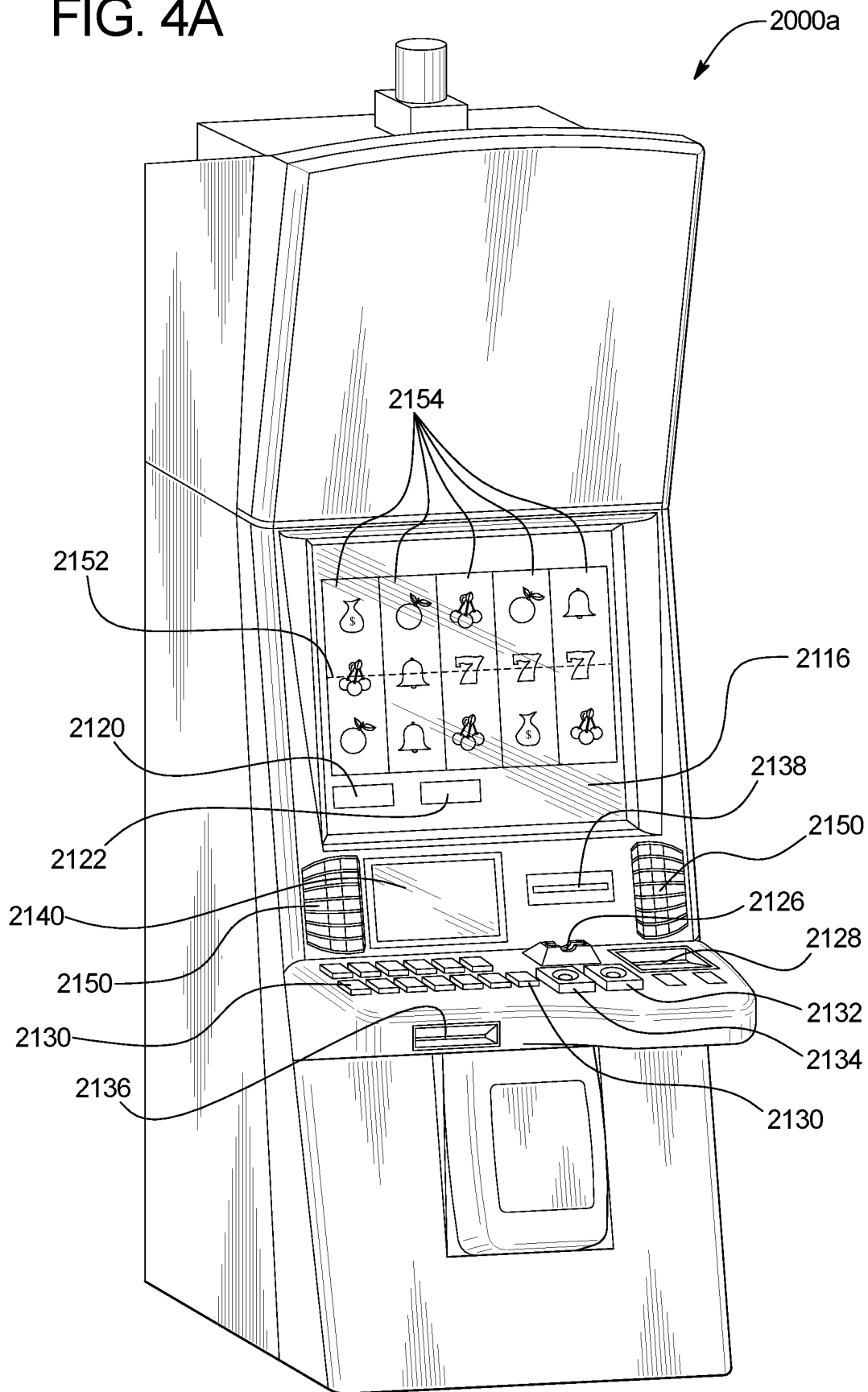


FIG. 4B

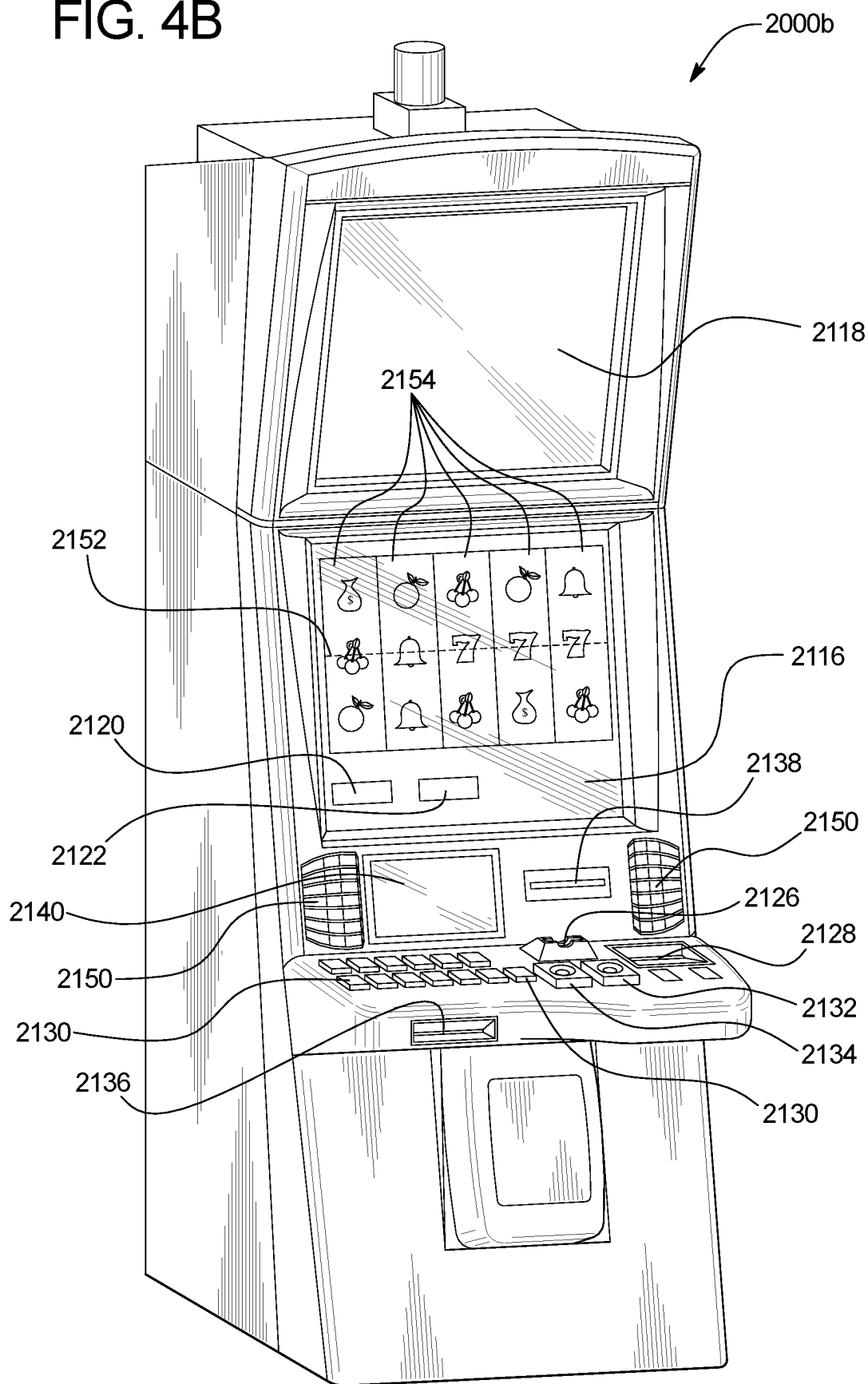
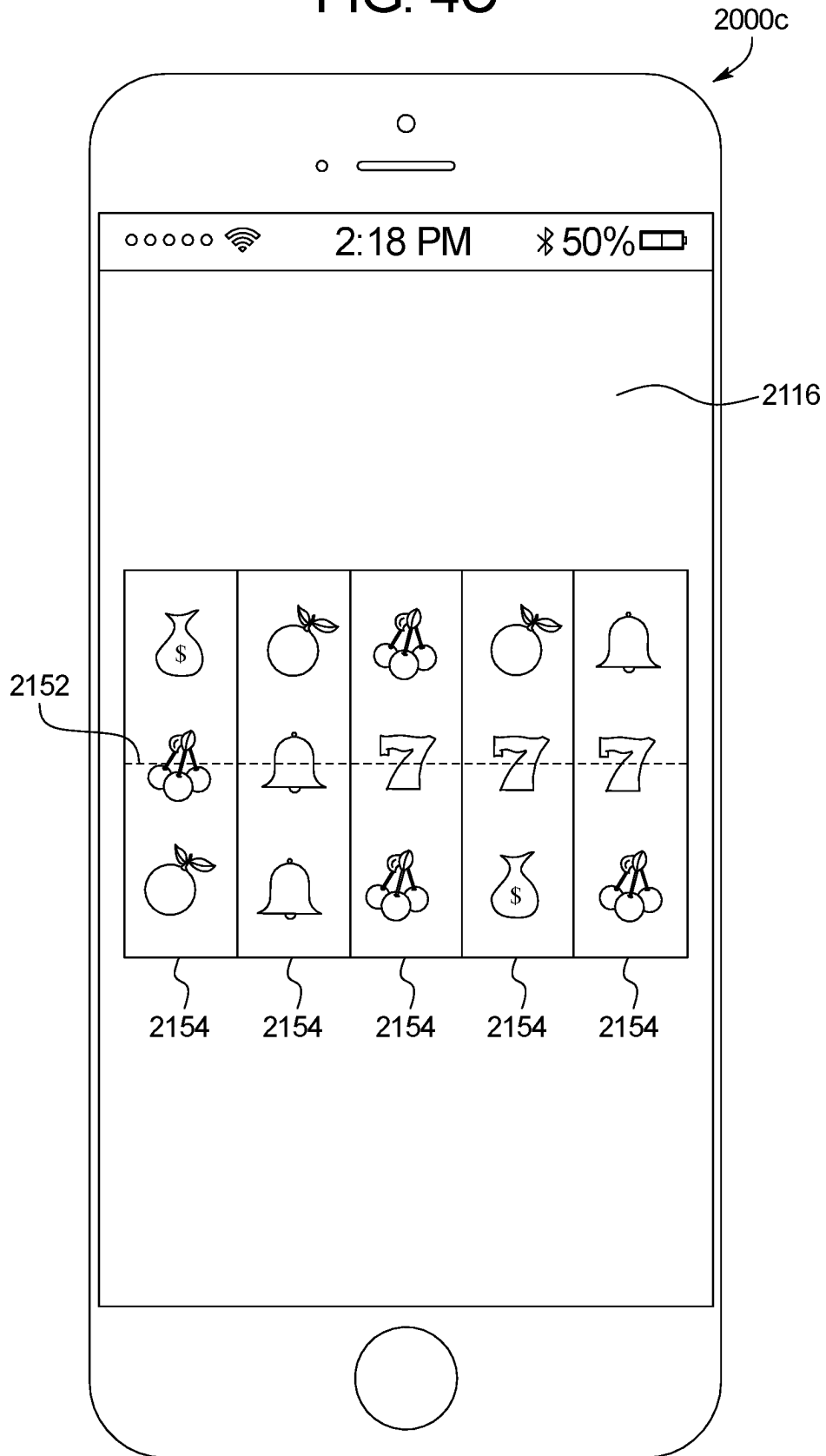


FIG. 4C



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GAMING SYSTEM AND METHOD FOR OFFERING SOCIAL MEDIA ACTIVITY IN ASSOCIATION WITH WAGERING

PRIORITY CLAIM

This application is a continuation of, claims the benefit of and priority to U.S. patent application Ser. No. 16/589,820, filed on Oct. 1, 2019, the entire contents of which is incorporated by reference herein.

TECHNICAL FIELD

The technical field of the present disclosure is that of gaming systems and specifically gaming systems which offer social media activity in association with wagering on one or more games of chance, one or more games of skill, and/or one or more sporting events.

BACKGROUND

Developing and maintaining a loyal customer base is one component of operating a successful gaming establishment. To develop a loyal customer base, gaming establishments, such as casinos, attempt to generate interactions with their patrons that provide a unique and personalized experience. As an example, gaming establishments offer patrons the opportunity to participate in a player loyalty program via which patrons are offered various promotions that encourage the patron to return to the gaming establishment.

BRIEF SUMMARY

In certain embodiments, the present disclosure relates to a gaming system including a processor, and a memory device that stores a plurality of instructions. When executed by the processor, the instructions cause the processor to communicate data that results in a display device displaying an amount of a progressive award. When executed by the processor responsive to a social media activity event occurring in association with social media content generated in association with a gaming establishment and distributed on a social media site, the instructions cause the processor to modify an amount of the progressive award, and communicate data that results in the display device displaying the modified amount of the progressive award.

In certain embodiments, the present disclosure relates to a gaming system including a processor, and a memory device that stores a plurality of instructions. When executed by the processor, the instructions cause the processor to communicate data that results in a display device displaying a progressive award. When executed by the processor responsive to a social media activity event occurring in association with social media content generated in association with a gaming establishment and distributed on a social media site, the instructions cause the processor to associate a progressive award opportunity with a player, and communicate data that results in the display device displaying the associated progressive award opportunity.

In certain embodiments, the present disclosure relates to a gaming system including a processor, and a memory device that stores a plurality of instructions. When executed by the processor for a play of a game, the instructions cause the processor to determine a game outcome, communicate data that results in a first display device displaying the game outcome, determine social media content associated with the game outcome, and communicate data that results in a

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second display device displaying the social media content until a designated amount of social media activity has occurred in association with the displayed social media content.

Additional features are described herein, and will be apparent from the following Detailed Description and the figures.

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE FIGURES

FIG. 1 is a flow chart an example process for operating a gaming system which distributes social media content on a player's behalf.

FIGS. 2A and 2B are example graphical player interfaces displayed on a display device of an electronic gaming machine illustrating a play of a game and a social media content distribution event occurring in association with the play of the game.

FIG. 2C illustrates an example portion of a gaming establishment including several electronic gaming machines that each display social media content following the occurrence of a social media content distribution event in association with the play of the game of FIGS. 2A and 2B.

FIG. 3 is a schematic block diagram of one embodiment of an electronic configuration of an example gaming system disclosed herein.

FIGS. 4A and 4B are perspective views of example alternative embodiments of the gaming system disclosed herein.

FIG. 4C is a front view of an example personal gaming device of the gaming system disclosed herein.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

In various embodiments, the gaming system and method disclosed herein provides zero, one or more social media benefits to a player in addition to any awards provided to that player in association with a play of a game.

In certain embodiments, following an occurrence of a social media content distribution event, such as the random determination of an outcome during a play of a game on an electronic gaming machine ("EGM"), the gaming system distributes social media content associated with the player, such as social media content associated with a player's gaming experience, on the player's behalf. In these embodiments, as part of one or more awards provided to a player in association with one or more games played at an EGM and/or as part of one or more payouts provided to a player in association with one more winning sporting event wagers placed, the gaming system disclosed herein distributes social media content associated with the player to one or more other players at other EGMs and/or on one or more social media sites. In such embodiments, since certain players value social media coverage regarding their social media accounts at least as much as such players value monetary awards associated with winning game outcomes and/or monetary payouts associated with winning sporting event wagers, the gaming system provides social media coverage to these players in addition to (or alternative from) any monetary awards associated with winning game outcomes and/or monetary payouts associated with winning sporting event wagers. For example, upon obtaining a designated game outcome during a play of a game of chance on an EGM, rather than providing the player a \$50 award associated with the designated game outcome, the gaming system causes five-hundred other EGMs in the gaming establishment to each display social media content associated with

the player and requests players at these EGMs to make one or more inputs regarding the displayed social media content. As illustrated by this example, the gaming system provides a player with social media coverage (e.g., distributing social media content associated with the player via one or more distribution channels not otherwise available to the player) as a form of an award won in association with the player's gaming experience. Such a configuration enables certain players to bolster their social media presence via utilizing the gaming system (and specifically the display devices in the gaming establishment and/or the people in the social media network of the various social media accounts maintained by the gaming establishment) to distribute social media content on the player's behalf to others whom would not otherwise view the player's social media content.

While certain embodiments described below are directed to distributing social media content associated with a player in association with one or more plays of a primary game, such as a primary wagering game, it should be appreciated that such embodiments may additionally or alternatively be employed in association with distributing social media content associated with a player in association with one or more plays of a secondary game, such as a bonus game or a communal game. Additionally, while the player's credit balance, and the player's wager are displayed as an amount of monetary credits or currency in certain of the embodiments described below, one or more of such player's credit balance, and/or such player's wager may be for non-monetary credits, promotional credits, and/or player tracking points or credits. Furthermore, the term "EGM" is used herein to refer to any suitable electronic gaming machine which enables a player to play one or more games and/or place one or more sporting event wagers, wherein the EGM comprises, but is not limited to: a slot machine, a video poker machine, a video lottery terminal, a terminal associated with an electronic table game, a video keno machine, a video bingo machine located on a casino floor, and a sports betting terminal.

FIG. 1 is a flowchart of an example process or method of operating the gaming system of the present disclosure. In various embodiments, the process is represented by a set of instructions stored in one or more memories and executed by one or more processors. Although the process is described with reference to the flowchart shown in FIG. 1, many other processes of performing the acts associated with this illustrated process may be employed. For example, the order of certain of the illustrated blocks or diamonds may be changed, certain of the illustrated blocks or diamonds may be optional, or certain of the illustrated blocks or diamonds may not be employed.

In various embodiments, upon an occurrence of a game initiation event, the gaming system initiates a play of a game as indicated in block 102 of FIG. 1.

In certain embodiments, the game comprises a play of a primary game, such as a primary wagering game, wherein the game initiation event includes the placement of a wager on the play of the primary game. In certain embodiments, the game comprises a play of a secondary game, such as a free spin game, wherein the game initiation event occurs based on a displayed event associated with a play of a primary game. In certain embodiments wherein the game comprises a secondary game, such as a free spin game, the game initiation event occurs based on an event independent of any displayed event associated with the play of the primary game.

In certain embodiments, the play of the game is implemented as a game of chance (and/or a game of skill) in a

networked environment, such as over the internet, in which the gaming system enables a plurality of players to each participate simultaneously in plays of the game using their own personal electronic device. For example, the gaming system enables a plurality of players to access those gaming systems via one or more web browsers running on one or more personal gaming devices.

In certain embodiments, the play of the game is implemented as a casual or social game of chance (and/or a casual or social game of skill) playable via social networks or online casinos in a networked environment which employ virtual currency in the form of virtual points or credits which may not be redeemed for any monetary value (contrasted with land-based casinos which employ credits redeemable for monetary currency). In certain such embodiments, the casual or social game requires the player to place a virtual currency wager to activate the casual or social game.

In certain other embodiments, the play of the game is implemented as a game of chance (and/or a game of skill) playable in a gaming environment, such as a play of an EGM at a land-based casino, which employs currency in the form of monetary credits (which can be redeemed for monetary value). In certain such embodiments, the game of chance requires the player to place a monetary wager to activate the game of chance.

It should be appreciated that when the game is implemented as a game of skill, the gaming system enables a player to make one or more quantifiable skill inputs to manipulate, influence or otherwise control one or more aspects of the game of skill (and thus influence or otherwise affect the outcome of the game of skill). In these embodiments, a player's skill is determined and quantified by one or more inputs (or the lack of any inputs) by the player that tend to measure one or more aspects of the player's skill. For example, skill includes utilizing one or more skill input devices to exhibit: (i) physical skill, such as, but not limited to: timing, aim, physical strength or any combination thereof which is quantifiable by zero, one or more inputs made by the player in association with the game of skill; (ii) mental skill (i.e., knowledge, reasoning, and/or strategy) which is quantifiable by one or more inputs made by the player (or the lack of any inputs made by the player) in association with the game of skill; and (iii) any other type of skill which is quantifiable by one or more inputs made by the player (or the lack of any inputs made by the player) in association with the game of skill. Such skill input devices include, but are not limited to: joysticks, buttons, a mouse or a plurality of mice, one or more trackballs, one or more pointing devices, a personal gaming device, such as a mobile device, one or more bodily motion trackers such as motion sensing devices for human-computer interaction, touchpads, touchscreens, one or more controllers with: (1) one or more motion sensing devices, (2) one or more proximity sensing devices, (3) one or more force sensing devices (transducers), (4) one or more accelerometers, or any other suitable skill input devices.

It should be appreciated that while illustrated as a play of a slot game, the gaming system disclosed herein may distribute social media content in association with any play of any suitable game including, but not limited to: a play of any suitable slot game; a play of any suitable wheel game; a play of any suitable table game (whether played at a gaming table or from an EGM remote from the gaming table) including, but not limited to: a play of any suitable card game, such as but not limited to any suitable poker game (including, but not limited to, Texas Hold'em, Omaha, Three Card Poker, Four Card Poker, Seven Card Stud, Pai Gow Poker, Caribbean Stud Poker, Let It Ride Poker), any

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suitable blackjack game, any suitable Baccarat game, any suitable Spanish 21 game, any suitable Casino War game, any suitable Super Fun 21 game, and any suitable Vegas Three Card Rummy game, a play of any suitable craps game, and/or a play of any suitable roulette game; a play of any suitable offer and acceptance game; a play of any suitable award ladder game; a play of any suitable puzzle-type game; a play of any suitable persistence game; a play of any suitable selection game; a play of any suitable cascading symbols game; a play of any suitable ways to win game; a play of any suitable scatter pay game; a play of any suitable coin-pusher game; a play of any suitable elimination game; a play of any suitable trail game; a play of any suitable bingo game; a play of any suitable video scratch-off game; a play of any suitable pick-until-complete game; a play of any suitable shooting simulation game; a play of any suitable racing game; a play of any suitable promotional game; a play of any suitable high-low game; a play of any suitable lottery game; a play of any suitable number selection game; a play of any suitable dice game; a play of any suitable skill game; a play of any suitable auction game; a play of any suitable reverse-auction game; a play of any suitable group game; a play of any suitable game in a service window; a play of any suitable game on a mobile device; and/or a play of any suitable game disclosed herein. It should be appreciated that while illustrated as a play of a slot game, the gaming system disclosed herein may distribute social media content in association with any suitable live sporting event, historic sporting event (e.g., a prerecorded sporting event), recreated sporting event (e.g., an animated representation of a historic sporting event), simulated sporting event (e.g., a sporting event created from different parts of different historical sporting events wherein zero, one or more results of such a simulated sporting event are randomly determined) and/or electronic sporting event (e.g., a virtual or electronic sport event played by humans, by computer driven participants or by a mix of human and computer driven participants) of any suitable sport at any professional and/or amateur level including, but not limited to, football, basketball, baseball, boxing, horse racing, wrestling, mixed martial arts, golf, cricket, soccer, hockey, field hockey, tennis, volleyball, table tennis, rugby, swimming, diving, archery, cycling, billiards, fishing, gymnastics, hunting, track and field, sailing, and/or car racing.

Following the initiation of the play of the game, the gaming system determines and displays a game outcome as indicated in blocks 104 and 106 of FIG. 1. In certain embodiments wherein the game is a game of chance, the gaming system determines the game outcome based on one or more random determinations. For example, as seen in FIGS. 2A and 2B, if the initiated game is a reel game, the gaming system spins a plurality of reels 202a to 202e (as seen in FIG. 2A) to display a plurality of symbols 204a to 204o at a plurality of symbol display positions 206a to 206o (as seen in FIG. 2B). In certain embodiments wherein the game is a game of skill, the gaming system determines the game outcomes based on zero, one or more skill-based inputs made (or not made) in association with the play of the game of skill.

In addition to determining and displaying a game outcome, the gaming system determines if the determined game outcome is associated with a social media content distribution event as indicated by diamond 108 of FIG. 1. That is, prior to displaying any award associated with the determined game outcome, the gaming system determines if a social media award feature is activated in association with the play of the game, wherein the activation or deactivation of such

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a feature determines a form of any award to be provided to the player in association with the play of the game.

In certain embodiments, the gaming system determines if a social media award feature is activated based on an operation mode of the gaming system. In these embodiments, an operator of the gaming system, such as gaming establishment personnel, place one or more EGMs in social media award mode wherein, per the payable utilized, one or more awards take the form of social media awards. In certain embodiments, the gaming system determines if a social media award feature is activated responsive to a player input. In these embodiments, a social media award feature is activated responsive to a player input to utilize a payable wherein one or more awards take the form of social media awards.

In certain embodiments, the gaming system enables any player to make one or more inputs to activate a social media award feature and elect for one or more awards to take the form of social media awards. In certain embodiments, the gaming system enables any identified player, such as a player identified via a player tracking system, to make one or more inputs to activate a social media award feature (wherein non-identified players cannot make such inputs to activate the social media award feature). In certain embodiments, the gaming system enables certain identified players, such as a player identified via a player tracking system whom has a player tracking status above a threshold status, to make one or more inputs to activate a social media award feature (wherein non-identified players and identified players with a player tracking status below the threshold status cannot make such inputs to activate the social media award feature). In certain embodiments, the gaming system enables any player associated with a gaming establishment mobile device application to make one or more inputs to activate a social media award feature (wherein players not associated with the gaming establishment mobile device application cannot make such inputs to activate the social media award feature).

In certain embodiments, the gaming system enables qualified player to make one or more inputs to activate a social media award feature (wherein non-qualified players cannot make such inputs to activate the social media award feature). In one such embodiment, a player qualifies to activate the social media feature based on an amount of wagers placed during one or more gaming sessions. In another such embodiment, a player qualifies to activate the social media feature based on an amount of time spent playing one or more games. In another such embodiment, a player qualifies to activate the social media feature based on an amount of winnings during one or more gaming sessions. In another such embodiment, a player qualifies to activate the social media feature based on sharing (or agreeing to share) social media content associated with a gaming establishment, such as an image or video of the EGM win (wherein the player is advertising the gaming establishment and game brand on social media in return for the eligibility of winning the social media benefit).

In certain embodiments, the gaming system enables the player to elect to win one or more awards in the form of social media awards wherein the gaming system determines (or generates) the social media content distributed as the social media award. In these embodiments, the gaming system generates social media content based on the player's gaming/non-gaming experience (as described below) for distribution and/or selects player generated social media content for distribution. In certain embodiments, in addition to electing to win one or more awards in the form of social

media awards, the gaming system enables the player to select the type of social media award they prefer, such as the type of social media content the player prefers to be distributed as the social media award. In one such embodiment, the gaming system enables the player to associate social media content with their gaming establishment account, such as a player tracking account or a cashless wagering account, wherein upon a determination to distribute social media content of the player as part of an award, the gaming system utilizes the social media content associated with the player's gaming establishment account. In another such embodiment, the gaming system enables the player to associate one or more social media sites with their gaming establishment account, such as a player tracking account or a cashless wagering account, wherein upon a determination to distribute social media content of the player as part of an award, the gaming system communicates with the social media site to determine social media content to be distributed as part of the award. For example, the gaming system enables a player to utilize a gaming establishment mobile device application, an EGM and/or a service window to enter one or more uniform resource locators ("URLs") of one or more of social media sites which the player maintains a social media account, wherein upon a determination to distribute social media content of the player as part of an award, the gaming system utilizes such URLs to determine social media content to be distributed as part of the award.

In certain embodiments, in addition to electing to win one or more awards in the form of social media awards, the gaming system enables the player (or the gaming system operator) to select if they prefer part or all of one or more awards in the form of social media awards. In one such embodiment, the gaming system enables the player (or the gaming system operator) to make one or more inputs to utilize a payable wherein certain awards associated with certain game outcomes of the payable are monetary awards and certain awards associated with certain game outcomes of the payable take the form of social media awards. In another such embodiment, the gaming system enables the player (or the gaming system operator) to make one or more inputs to utilize a payable wherein certain awards associated with certain game outcomes of the payable may take the form of monetary awards, social media awards, or a combination of partial monetary award/partial social media award. In another such embodiment, the gaming system enables the player (or the gaming system operator) to make one or more inputs to utilize a payable wherein each of the awards associated with each of the game outcomes of the payable take the form of social media awards.

In certain embodiments, the player inputs regarding one or more social media awards occurs prior to the play of the game, such as following receipt of an input from a player to configure the form and type of one or more awards which may be provided to the player for a subsequent play of the game. In one embodiment, a social media award feature is activated responsive to a player logging into the gaming system (either from an EGM or remote from the EGM, such as a player logging into the gaming system using a mobile device application associated with a gaming establishment) and configuring a player account that the player prefers to win social media awards. In another embodiment, a social media award feature is activated responsive to one or more inputs made by the player prior to a gaming session to indicate that the player prefers to win social media awards. For example, at the beginning of a gaming session, the gaming system enables the player to enter the URL associated with social media content wherein upon a winning

game outcome (or a designated winning game outcome), the gaming system utilizes the entered URL to determine social media content to distribute as part of the award associated with the winning game outcome. In another embodiment, the input occurs during the play of the game, such as prior to or after the display of the game outcome. In this embodiment, following the presentation of a winning game outcome, the gaming system prompts the player to make one or more inputs to indicate the form of payment of the winning game outcome. For example, upon a winning game outcome, the gaming system prompts the player to enter the URL for the social media content to share. In another example, upon a winning game outcome, the gaming system prompts the player to pair a mobile device with the EGM that they are playing at and upload social media content from the mobile device to the EGM to share.

Returning to FIG. 1, if the gaming system determines that the determined game outcome is associated with a social media content distribution event, as indicated in blocks 110 and 112, the gaming system determines social media content associated with the player and distributes the social media content associated with the player as part of the award associated with the determined game outcome. That is, in addition to (or in lieu of) providing any monetary award associated with determined game outcome, the gaming system determines and distributes social media content on the player's behalf in association with the determined game award. For example, as seen in FIG. 2B, upon determining that the symbol combination of cherry symbol 204b displayed at symbol display position 206b-cherry symbol 204e displayed at symbol display position 206e-cherry symbol 204h displayed at symbol display position 206h is associated with a social media content distribution event, the gaming system determines and distributes social media content associated with the player of that game (i.e., Player A) to each of the participating EGMs associated with the social media content distribution event. In this example, as seen in FIG. 2C, each of the participating EGMs display social media content associated with Player A and prompt the player at such participating EGMs to make one or more inputs to recognize the social media content associated with Player A, such as by liking or commenting on Player A's social media content.

It should be appreciated that while illustrated as a social media content distribution event occurring in association with the determination of an outcome of a play of a game, the social media content distribution event may occur in association with the player's gaming experience and/or the player's non-gaming experience at a gaming establishment. That is, the social media content distribution event may occur in association with any aspect of any game of chance, any game of skill, any lottery game, or any sporting event wagering activity (including, but not limited to, any sporting event wagering activity associated with any live sporting event, any sporting event wagering activity associated with any historic sporting event, any sporting event wagering activity associated with any recreated sporting event, any sporting event wagering activity associated with any simulated sporting event and/or any sporting event wagering activity associated with any electronic sporting event) or may occur independent of any aspect of any game of chance, any game of skill, any lottery game or any sporting event wagering activity. It should be further appreciated that while described in association with distributing social media content based on a player's interaction with an EGM, in different embodiments, the gaming system distributes social media content in association with a player's interaction with

any suitable gaming establishment component, such as a sports betting kiosk, a gaming table, and/or a gaming terminal associated with a gaming table. For example, the distributed social media content is based on images captured from or in association with a gaming table including an image capture device or other mechanisms for capturing information about the game played at the gaming table. In this example, a camera is positioned above the gaming table, such that outcomes of games played on the gaming table can be captured in images from the camera. In this example, in response to certain events, such as the player obtaining a certain outcome in the game played on the gaming table, social media information related to the game play at the gaming table is captured as social media content for distribution.

In certain embodiments, the social media content distribution event occurs based on any event or series of events associated with the player's gaming experience, such as one or more plays of any game of chance, one or more plays of any game of skill, one or more plays of a lottery game or one or more sporting event wagers placed. For example, if a player wins a certain lottery prize, social media content associated with the player is distributed through various distribution channels associated with the lottery, such as shared on the lottery website, displayed on lottery billboards, and/or displayed at lottery terminals. In different embodiments, such events include, but are not limited to: the presentation of any outcome, the presentation of a designated outcome, the presentation of a sequence of outcomes, the presentation of any award, the presentation of a designated award, the presentation of an award over a threshold value, the presentation of a sequence of awards, the placement of a sporting event wager, the placement of a sporting event wager over a threshold value, winning a placed sporting event wager, winning a placed sporting event wager over a threshold value, the presentation of a qualifying losing outcome (e.g., the presentation of nearly hitting a progressive award but being off by one symbol), the triggering of a bonus game, the activation of a feature of a game, the accumulation of a quantity of one or more collectible elements, the cashing out of a quantity of player points (e.g., converting 10,000 player points to receive a buffet ticket), the deposit of funds to play one or more games, the cashing out of winnings from one or more game, and/or a detection of a player's biometric data, such as a player's monitored heartbeat or captured facial expression, being associated with a triggering event which occurs during a play of a game.

In certain embodiments, the social media content distribution event occurs based on any event or series of events associated with the player's non-gaming experience. In different embodiments, such social media content distribution events include, but are not limited to: a redemption of a quantity of player tracking points (e.g., converting player tracking points for the distribution of social media content associated with the player on the player's behalf or converting player tracking points for an extension of the distribution of social media content associated with the player previously distributed on the player's behalf), a purchase of a social media content distribution event (e.g., a player using funds from a player account and/or a credit balance to purchase the distribution of social media content associated with the player on the player's behalf or converting purchasing an extension of the distribution of social media content associated with the player previously distributed on the player's behalf), a player visiting one or more locations of a gaming establishment, a player making one or more purchases at one

or more retail locations of a gaming establishment, a player making one or more designated purchases at one or more retail locations of a gaming establishment, a player attending one or more events at a gaming establishment, a player utilizing one or more gaming establishment services, a player attending a club and/or show associated with a gaming establishment, a player taking a picture associated with the gaming establishment (e.g., a player taking a skyline picture that includes the gaming establishment), a player observing one or more other people, such as a player taking a picture of a celebrity or a uniquely dressed person at a gaming establishment, and/or a player observing the activity of other people, such as a player taking a picture of another patron winning a progressive award.

In certain embodiments, upon a determination that a social media content distribution event occurred, the gaming system distributes social media content associated with the player to a plurality of display devices located in or otherwise associated with a gaming establishment. In certain embodiments, such display devices include one or more display devices of one or more EGMs. In certain embodiments, such display devices additionally or alternatively include one or more community or overhead display devices. In certain embodiments, such display devices additionally or alternatively include one or more display devices of one or more mobile devices that are in communication with the gaming system, such as mobile devices executing a gaming establishment mobile device application that can display social media content. In certain embodiments, such display devices additionally or alternatively include one or more display devices at one or more kiosks. In certain embodiments, upon a determination that a social media content distribution event occurred, the gaming system distributes social media content associated with the player to one or more social media sites associated with the player and/or associated with the gaming establishment.

In certain embodiments, upon a determination that a social media content distribution event occurred, the gaming system distributes social media content associated with the player to a plurality of display devices located in or otherwise associated with a single property gaming establishment. In certain other embodiments, upon a determination that a social media content distribution event occurred, the gaming system distributes social media content associated with the player to a plurality of display devices located in or otherwise associated with a plurality of single property gaming establishments and/or multiple property gaming establishments. In certain other embodiments, upon a determination that a social media content distribution event occurred, the gaming system additionally or alternatively distributes social media content associated with the player to a plurality of display devices associated with one or more non-gaming establishment properties. For example, upon a determination that a social media content distribution event occurred, the gaming system causes social media content associated with a player to be displayed via one or more kiosks located in an airport and/or a stadium.

In certain embodiments, the gaming system varies the amount of distributed social media content associated with the player such that different social media distribution events are associated with different amounts of distributed social media content. In these embodiments, the amount of distributed social media content includes a quantity of display devices which will display the social media content, which display devices will display the social media content, the length of time one or more display devices will display the social media content, a quantity of social media sites which

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the social media content will be distributed to, a quantity of social media accounts which the social media content will be distributed in association with and/or which social media sites and/or social media accounts the social media content will be distributed in association with.

In certain embodiments wherein the gaming system distributes social media content associated with the player via causing such social media content to be displayed on one or more display devices, the gaming system distributes the amount of social media content associated with the player for a predetermined amount of time. In another such embodiment, the gaming system distributes the amount of social media content associated with the player until another social media distribution event occurs and the gaming system displays different social media content (either associated with the same player, a different player or the gaming establishment). In another such embodiment, the gaming system distributes the amount of social media content associated with the player until the distributed social media content has obtained a threshold amount of recognition, such as a certain quantity of views, likes, comments or other social media activity. In this embodiment, the gaming system maintains the display of social media content associated with the player, such as a picture of the player's reaction to obtaining a jackpot during a play of a game, until a designated amount of social media activity is associated with the displayed social media content. Such a configuration thus provides the player with a variable length of social media content distribution but a static amount of social media activity in the form of social media content recognition.

In certain embodiments, the gaming system varies the amount of distributed social media content associated with the player based on one or more factors related to the play of the game. In one such embodiment, the gaming system determines the amount of social media content associated with the player to distribute based on the amount of the wager placed on the play of the game. In this embodiment, if a social media content distribution event occurs when a first wager amount is placed, the gaming system distributes a first amount of social media content associated with the player and if a social media content distribution event occurs when a second, different wager amount is placed, the gaming system distributes a second, different amount of social media content associated with the player. In another such embodiment, the gaming system determines the amount of social media content associated with the player to distribute based on the determined game outcome. In this embodiment, if a first game outcome is associated with a social media content distribution event, the gaming system distributes a first amount of social media content associated with the player and if a second, different game outcome is associated with a social media content distribution event, the gaming system distributes a second, different amount of social media content associated with the player.

In certain embodiments, the gaming system varies the amount of distributed social media content associated with the player based on one or more factors related to the player. In one such embodiment, the gaming system determines the amount of social media content associated with the player to distribute based on a player tracking status of the player, wherein if a social media content distribution event occurs, the gaming system distributes a first amount of social media content associated with a first player having a first player tracking status and distributes a second, different amount of social media content associated with a second player having a second player tracking status. In another such embodiment, the gaming system determines the amount of social

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media content associated with the player to distribute based on whether or not the player has downloaded a gaming establishment mobile device application to their mobile device, wherein if a social media content distribution event occurs, the gaming system distributes a first amount of social media content associated with a first player whom has downloaded the gaming establishment mobile device application to their mobile device and distributes a second, different amount of social media content associated with a second player whom has not downloaded the gaming establishment mobile device application to their mobile device.

In certain embodiments, the gaming system varies the amount of distributed social media content associated with the player based on one or more factors related to the social media content. In one such embodiment, the gaming system determines the amount of social media content associated with the player to distribute based on whether the social media content is player generated or gaming system generated. In another such embodiment, the gaming system determines the amount of social media content associated with the player to distribute based on an amount of recognition, such as a certain quantity of views, likes, comments or other social media activity, the distributed social media content has when distributed and/or acquires after distribution.

In certain embodiments, upon a determination that a social media content distribution event has occurred, the gaming system distributes the social media content associated with the player when the social media content distribution event occurs. In certain embodiments, upon a determination that a social media content distribution event has occurred, the gaming system queues the social media content associated with the player for distribution at a subsequent point in time. In one such embodiment, the gaming system enables the player to schedule or choose a time when the queued social media content will be distributed as part of the award. In another such embodiment, the gaming system determines when queued social media content will be distributed as part of the award.

In various embodiments, the social media content distributed as part of the award includes social media content generated in association with the player's gaming experience, social media content generated in association with a player's non-gaming experience at a gaming establishment, and/or player generated social media content (e.g., social media content previously generated by the player and either previously uploaded to a social media account associated with the player or saved in association with the player's gaming establishment account to be distributed as a social media award). In these embodiments, the social media content includes one or more social media content components in one or more media formats. In such embodiments, the social media content components includes one or more of: still images (e.g., a screen capture of an outcome of a play of a game or a picture the player previously uploaded to a social media network), video clips (e.g., a video recording of a play of a game or a video clip the player previously uploaded to a social media network), sound clips (e.g., a player's verbal reaction to a play of a game), audio-video clips, text (e.g., a meme the player previously posted to their social media account or an advertisement promoting an upcoming event at a gaming establishment), social media site information (e.g. a URL of a social media site), transaction information (e.g., an amount spent purchasing goods at a gaming establishment's luxury clothing store), location information, application usage information,

social media site information and statistics, event attendance information, and/or biometric information.

In certain embodiments, the social media content components are combinable with contextual information, such as information about the person, place and time, and then formatted to generate the social media content. For example, first social media content includes a plurality of images selected from a presentation of a game outcome at an EGM and text describing the type of game on which a designated award was won, the gaming establishment where the designated award was won, the gaming establishment's location and information about the person that won the designated award, such as their name. In another example, second social media content includes an embedded audio/video clip, such as a promotional audio/video clip of a concert, along with attendance information regarding a player attending the concert, and the gaming establishment where the concert occurred.

In certain embodiments wherein the social media content is generated in association with the player's gaming experience and/or non-gaming experience at a gaming establishment, the gaming system utilizes one or more devices to generate social media content to be distributed. For example, when a user, such as a player, rides a new roller coaster at a gaming establishment (i.e., the occurrence of the social media content distribution event), the user selects one or more images of themselves on the roller coaster (taken from a camera associated with the roller coaster) and a maximum heart rate while they rode the roller coaster (as determined by one or more wearable devices in communication with and configured to share data with a mobile device application associated with the gaming establishment). In this example, the gaming system utilizes the selected social media content components (plus the social media content component of a logo associated with the gaming establishment) to create or generate social media content to be distributed. In another example, when a user purchases a good from a retail location of a gaming establishment, a retail point-of-sale terminal associated with the gaming establishment selects one or more social media content components of one or more images of the purchased good, a sale price associated with the purchased good and a logo of the gaming establishment where the purchased occurred. In this example, the retail point-of-sale terminal associated with the gaming establishment utilizes the selected social media content components to create or generate social media content to be distributed.

In addition to distributing the social media content to one or more other devices located in or otherwise associated with one or more gaming establishments, in certain embodiments wherein the gaming system generates social media content associated with the player, the gaming system causes the generated social media content to be uploaded to one or more social media sites. That is, social media content derived from activities of a player within a gaming establishment can be posted to an account at a social media site (e.g., Facebook™, Google+™, Twitter™, Instagram™, LinkedIn™, Snapchat™, YouTube™ (such as posting to a dedicated channel of players that win awards over a threshold value), Pinterest™, Tumblr™, Flickr™, Reddit™, Quora™, Vine™, and/or Periscope™). In these embodiments, to enable information, such as the generated social media content, to be posted to a social media site, such information is transferred from one or more components associated with a gaming establishment, such as an EGM, a server, and/or a mobile device running a mobile device application associated with the gaming establishment, to one

or more devices located outside of the gaming system and associated with the social media site.

In certain of these embodiments, a component associated with a gaming establishment uploads the generated social media content to a remote server. In these embodiments, a player subsequently retrieves the generated social media content from the server and posts such social media content to their social media account. For example, an EGM sends social media related information to a server and outputs a link, such as a URL link, to the information. In this embodiment, via the URL link, the player can view and retrieve the social media content and, if the player desires, post the retrieved social media content to their social media account.

In certain of these embodiments, a component associated with the gaming establishment uploads the generated social media content to a mobile device in communication with the component associated with the gaming establishment. For example, an EGM uploads the generated social media content to a mobile device paired to the EGM (or a component of a gaming establishment management system, such as a slot machine interface board ("SMIB"), associated with the EGM). In these embodiments, following the receipt of the generated social media content (and possibly the addition of certain messages by the player of the mobile device), the mobile device application posts the social media content to a social media site via any suitable communication protocol, such as one or more cellular communication standards (e.g., 3G, 4G, LTE), and/or one or more Wi-Fi compatible standards.

It should be appreciated that in certain embodiments, utilizing a mobile device application to participate in social media activity is in addition to various activities which a player of a mobile device can facilitate through a mobile device application, such as transferring funds (either as cashless credits, non-cashable credits, promotional funds) from one gaming establishment account to another gaming establishment account, logging a player into a gaming establishment loyalty account, such as a player tracking system account, and logging a player out of a gaming establishment loyalty account.

In certain embodiments wherein in addition to distributing the social media content to one or more other devices located in or otherwise associated with one or more gaming establishments, the gaming system generates social media content associated with the player to be uploaded to one or more social media sites, the player supplies social media site information, such as player account information that enables the generated social media content to be directly uploaded to the player's social media account of the social media site. For example, an EGM receives social media account information for a player's Facebook™ account and then sends a message including the generated social media content, such as information related to a sequence of consecutive wins to the player's account at social media site. In this example, if specified by the player, the information can be posted directly to their "wall" on Facebook™ where other authorized Facebook™ players can view the information. In this example, the message additionally or alternatively includes information that changes a "status" associated with the account.

In another embodiment wherein in addition to distributing the social media content to one or more other devices located in or otherwise associated with one or more gaming establishments, the gaming system generates social media content associated with the player to be uploaded to one or more social media sites, the gaming system additionally or alternatively posts social media information to a gaming estab-

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lishment operator account at a social media site. For example, after a player wins a progressive award, an EGM or server posts social media information, such as social media content including information about the progressive award win, to the gaming establishment operator's account at the social media site. In this example, from the gaming establishment operator's account, other players at the site with connections to the gaming establishment operator's account, such as "friends" of the gaming establishment operator or players that "like" the gaming establishment operator can be notified of the progressive award win.

In another embodiment wherein in addition to distributing the social media content to one or more other devices located in or otherwise associated with one or more gaming establishments, the gaming system generates social media content associated with the player to be uploaded to one or more social media sites, the gaming system additionally or alternatively posts social media information to an EGM manufacturer account at a social media site. For example, an EGM or server sends a message including social media information to an EGM manufacturer's account of a social media network. In this example, the social media information included in the message is then sent to (or otherwise viewable by) individuals connected with the EGM manufacturer via the EGM manufacturer's social media account at the social media site.

It should be appreciated that in various embodiments wherein in addition to distributing the social media content to one or more other devices located in or otherwise associated with one or more gaming establishments, the gaming system generates social media content associated with the player to be uploaded to one or more social media sites, one or more messages including generated social media content are sent to one or more of a user's social media account, a gaming establishment operator's social media account and/or an EGM manufacturer's social media account for posting to the respective account. That is, the gaming system communicates the generated social media content to multiple accounts associated with multiple end users. It should be further appreciated that in various embodiments, one or more messages including generated social media content are sent, in the appropriate format, to one or more accounts of one or more social media sites. That is, the gaming system communicates the generated social media content in one or more formats to multiple accounts at multiple social media sites associated with one or more end users.

In certain of the embodiments wherein in addition to distributing the social media content to one or more other devices located in or otherwise associated with one or more gaming establishments, the gaming system generates social media content associated with the player to be uploaded to one or more social media sites, the gaming system requires the player to opt-in or otherwise expressly give permission to have one or more components of the gaming establishment post social media content to their social media account. In certain embodiments, the gaming system enables the player to opt out from having any social media content posted to their social media account by any component of the gaming establishment. In certain embodiments, the gaming system enables the player to approve and/or modify any social media postings by any component of the gaming establishment.

It should be further appreciated that while described as a player posting (or otherwise authorizing one or more components of the gaming establishment to post) social media content to one or more social media networks upon an occurrence of a social media content distribution event, any

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suitable sharing of social media content to one or more other people qualifies as an occurrence of a social media content distribution event. That is, while posting to a social media network, such as Facebook™ or Twitter™ are one form of distributing social media content associated with a gaming establishment, reviewing one or more aspects of a gaming establishment, such as reviewing a show seen at a gaming establishment or reviewing a gaming establishment restaurant eaten at, on one or more peer review sites, such as Yelp™ are another form of distributing social media content associated with the gaming establishment. In another form of distributing social media content associated with a gaming establishment include sending information to one or more other people via an e-mail, SMS or text message, a push notification sent to a mobile device, and/or a website posting.

In another embodiment, the gaming system maintains a progressive award wherein upon a social media content distribution event, the gaming system causes the gaming system to increase the progressive award in addition to distributing social media content associated with the player. For example, each time the gaming system distributes social media content associated with a player, the gaming system also increases the amount of the progressive award. It should be appreciated that in certain embodiments, different social media content distributed results in different increases of the progressive award and the gaming system may increase the progressive award based on other funding avenues, such as based on a portion of wagers placed and/or gaming establishment marketing funds.

Returning to FIG. 1, if the gaming system determines that a social media content distribution event did not occur in association with the determined game outcome, the gaming system determines and displays a non-social media content award associated with the determined game outcome as indicated in blocks 114 and 116. That is, upon a determination that no social media content will be distributed in association with the determined game outcome (either via the determined game outcome not being associated with any social media content distribution event or the player electing not to have any awards in the form of social media content distribution), the gaming system determines and displays the non-social media content distribution award associated with the determined game outcome. In certain embodiments, the non-social media content distribution award includes any suitable award, such as a quantity of monetary credits, a quantity of non-monetary credits, a quantity of promotional credits, a quantity of player tracking points, a progressive award, a modifier, such as a multiplier, a quantity of free plays of one or more games, a quantity of plays of one or more secondary or bonus games, a multiplier of a quantity of free plays of a game, one or more lottery based awards, such as lottery or drawing tickets, a wager match for one or more plays of one or more games, an increase in the average expected payback percentage for one or more plays of one or more games, one or more comps, such as a free meal at a buffet, a free night's stay at a hotel, an upgrade for a stay at a hotel, tickets to a show, a high value product such as a car, or a low value product, one or more bonus credits usable for online play, a lump sum of player tracking points or credits, a multiplier for player tracking points or credits, an increase in a membership or player tracking level, one or more coupons or promotions usable within and/or outside of the gaming establishment (e.g., a \$10 off coupon for a show), virtual goods associated with one or more gaming establishment components, and/or virtual goods not associated with any gaming establishment components.

In certain embodiments, in addition to distributing social media content associated with a player, the gaming system disclosed herein periodically determines whether a social media benefit triggering event occurred in association with any distributed social media content. That is, based on the amount of social media activity associated with social media content distributed on behalf of a player, the gaming system determines whether that player (or any other players) qualify for an additional benefit, such as an award.

In these embodiments, the social media content includes embedded tracking information, such as player identification information and/or location information. The tracking information, which may be part of the displayed portion of the social media content (e.g., the displayed player's name) and/or part of a non-displayed portion of the social media content, is utilized to track subsequent interactions that one or more other players or social media content viewers have with the social media content. In such embodiments, by associating a player's social media username with the embedded player identification information, the gaming system disclosed herein is operable to query the various social media services for each player to learn about that player's social media activity. In an additional or alternative embodiment, by associating a player's social media username with the embedded player identification information, the gaming system disclosed herein is operable to instruct the various social media services to notify the gaming system when social media activity associated with the player occurs for internal tracking and potential benefit determinations as described herein. In an additional or alternative embodiment, by associating a player's social media username with the embedded player identification information, the gaming system disclosed herein is operable to query the social media service for when certain social media activity associated with the player occurs for internal tracking and potential benefit determinations as described herein.

In certain embodiments, a social media benefit triggering event occurs when a social media content distribution event occurs. In these embodiments, the distribution of social media content associated with the player results in the player qualifying for a benefit, such as a chance to win an additional award.

In certain embodiments, a social media benefit triggering event occurs when one or more conditions are satisfied in association with one or more social media activities related to the distributed social media content. For example, if a player purchases a lottery ticket and posts social media content associated with the purchased lottery ticket, such as posting a portion of the numbers of the lottery ticket, the gaming system determines that the social media benefit triggering event occurs and the player is entitled to a benefit. In certain of these embodiments, the satisfaction of the condition is based on an amount of interaction that one or more people have with the social media content. In various embodiments, a condition associated with distributed social media content is satisfied when the distributed social media content achieves any one or more of: the distributed social media content obtains a designated quantity of likes across one or more social media networks, the distributed social media content obtains a designated quantity of forwards, such as retweets on Twitter™, the distributed social media content obtains a designated quantity of people commenting on the social media content, the distributed social media content obtains a designated quantity of people following the player associated with the social media content, and/or the distributed social media content obtains a designated quantity of other people commenting specially about the

subject matter of the social media content, such as commenting about the activity or brand associated with the social media content. It should be appreciated that different social media content (or the same social media content on different social media networks) may be associated with the same or different conditions that need to be satisfied to cause a social media benefit triggering event to occur.

In certain embodiment wherein the gaming system distributes the social media content associated with the player for a limited duration, during the period of time during which the gaming system distributes the social media content associated with the player, if a threshold amount of social media activity occurs in association with the distributed social media content, such as a threshold amount of people like, share or comment on the social media content during this period of time, the gaming system determines that a social media benefit triggering event occurs and the player is entitled to a benefit, such as an award, an amount of player tracking points, or a chance to obtain an award.

In another embodiment wherein the gaming system distributes the social media content associated with the player for a limited duration, the gaming system maintains a progressive award wherein during the period of time during which the gaming system distributes the social media content associated with the player, social media activity occurring in association with the distributed social media content (i.e., the occurrence of the social media benefit triggering event) causes the gaming system to increase the progressive award (i.e., the benefit). For example, each time the distributed social media content is liked, shared or commented on, the gaming system increases the amount of the progressive award. It should be appreciated that different social media activity results in different increases of the progressive award and the gaming system may increase the progressive award based on other funding avenues, such as based on a portion of wagers placed and/or gaming establishment marketing funds.

In certain embodiments, a social media benefit triggering event occurs when a posting of social media content occurs to one or more social media sites. In one such embodiment, the gaming system maintains a progressive award wherein social media activity occurring in association with social media content associated with the gaming system causes the gaming system to increase the progressive award. For example, the gaming establishment or EGM manufacturer has a social media account wherein each like, share or comment on the social media account of the gaming establishment or EGM manufacturer causes an increase to a progressive award. In this example, the progressive award may be won via one or more plays of a game as disclosed herein or as a social media benefit as disclosed herein. In another example, each time the social media content associated with the gaming establishment or EGM manufacturer is liked, shared or commented on by a player, the gaming system provides that player a chance to win the progressive award.

In certain embodiments, a social media benefit triggering event occurs when a player completes one or more social media activities associated with the distributed social media content. In certain embodiments, a social media benefit triggering event occurs when a player having at least a designated quantity of social network contacts completes one or more social media activities associated with the distributed social media content. In certain embodiments, a social media benefit triggering event occurs when a player completes a designated amount of social media activities associated with the distributed social media content within a

designated period of time (e.g., within one week, a player comments on ten social media posts associated with one or more player's wins at a gaming establishment). In certain embodiments, a social media benefit triggering event occurs when a player having at least a designated quantity of social media contacts completes a designated amount of social media activities associated with the distributed social media content within a designated period of time. In various embodiments, the social media activity associated with a social media benefit triggering event includes one or more of: a like of distributed social media content, a dislike of distributed social media content, a forwarding of social media content, such as a retweet on Twitter™, a comment on distributed social media content, establishing a new social media contact, such as a new friend on Facebook™, in association with distributed social media content, subscribing to a social media channel associated with a target, such as subscribing to a YouTube™ channel of a gaming establishment, sending an electronic communication, such as a text, email, or social media network message, regarding a social activity, receiving an electronic communication, such as a text, email, or social media network message, regarding a social media activity, using a mobile device application in association with distributed social media content, and/or using a mobile device application in association with a social media activity.

In certain embodiments, the gaming system has different thresholds of social media activity for different social media sites. For example, a first amount of social media activity associated with first social media content on one social media network may cause an occurrence of a social media benefit triggering event while a second, greater amount of social media activity associated with the first social media content on another social media network may cause an occurrence of a social media benefit triggering event.

In certain embodiments, the gaming system determines whether a social media benefit triggering event occurs based on the social media activity associated with social media content on one social media network. In certain other embodiments, the gaming system determines whether a social media benefit triggering event occurs based on the social media activity associated with social media content on multiple social media networks.

In certain embodiments, a social media benefit triggering event occurs in association with the player affiliated with the generation of the social media content. In certain embodiments, a social media benefit triggering event occurs in association with another player who is not affiliated with the generation of the social media content. In certain embodiments, a social media benefit triggering event occurs in association with both the player affiliated with the generation of the social media content and another player who is not affiliated with the generation of the social media content.

It should be appreciated that in various embodiments, the gaming system determines if a social media benefit triggering event occurs via software that monitors social media accounts. In these embodiments, in association with the tracking information embedded in the distributed social media content, the software sends one or more events associated with social media activity, such as likes on Facebook™, to a host system to count and monitor. Upon the host system determining that the monitored social media activity has reached a designated threshold within a designated period of time, the host system determines that a social media benefit triggering event has occurred.

In certain embodiments, the determination of any benefit is based on the social media activity associated with the

triggered social media benefit triggering event, wherein different social media activities are associated with different benefits. In certain additional or alternative embodiments, different periods of time over which such social media activities occurred are associated with different benefits. In these embodiments, the benefits are scaled based on time wherein different periods of time are associated with different benefits for the same social media activity.

In certain embodiments, the determination of the benefit is additionally or alternatively based on the identity of the player. In one such embodiment, different players having different status with the gaming establishment are offered different benefits. In this embodiment, the benefits are scaled by player club account status. In certain embodiments, the gaming system tracks and identifies players who are able to gain the most followers, likes and comments, wherein these identified players represent more feedback to the gaming establishment and thus receive a greater benefit for their social media activity than other players.

In certain embodiments, the determination of the benefit is additionally or alternatively based on one or more parameters of the gaming establishment, such as when the benefit is determined, and whether the gaming establishment prefers social media content posted to one social media network over another social media network.

In certain embodiments, the determined benefit includes a monetary award, such as a progressive award. In one such embodiment, the amount of the monetary award is based on the social media activity which occurred, wherein different social media activities are associated with different monetary awards. In another such embodiment, the amount of the monetary award is additionally or alternatively based on an identification of the player, such as based on a player tracking status of the player, wherein different player tracking statuses are associated with different monetary awards for the same or similar social media activities. In another such embodiment, the amount of the monetary award is additionally or alternatively associated with a duration in which the social media activity occurred, wherein different durations are associated with different monetary awards.

In certain embodiments, the determined benefit includes one or more subsequent plays of a game of chance (and/or a game of skill). In one such embodiment, a quantity of plays of the game of chance (and/or game of skill) is based on the social media activity which occurred, wherein different social media activities are associated with different quantities of plays of the game of chance (and/or game of skill). In another such embodiment, the quantity of plays of a game of chance (and/or game of skill) is additionally or alternatively based on an identification of the player, such as based on a player tracking status of the player, wherein different player tracking statuses are associated with different quantities of plays of a game of chance (and/or a game of skill) for the same or similar social media activities. In another such embodiment, the quantity of plays of a game of chance (and/or a game of skill) is additionally or alternatively associated with a duration in which the social media activity occurred, wherein different durations are associated with different quantities of plays of the game of chance (and/or game of skill). In certain embodiments, the determined benefit includes one or more free (or reduced cost) plays of one or more games of chance (and/or games of skill) the next time the player visits the gaming establishment. In certain other embodiments, the determined benefit includes one or more free (or reduced cost) plays of one or more online games of chance (and/or games of skill) accessible remote

from the gaming establishment. In these embodiments, such games include any game disclosed herein.

In certain embodiments, as indicated above, the determined benefit includes an entry in a drawing, such as an entry to win a progressive award. In one such embodiment, a quantity of entries in the drawing is based on the social media activity which occurred, wherein different social media activities are associated with different quantities of drawing entries. For example, the gaming system determines an entry into a drawing to win a progressive award for each fifty retweets on Twitter™ of a tweet associated with positive comments about a gaming establishment. In another such embodiment, the quantity of entries into a drawing is additionally or alternatively based on an identification of the player, such as based on a player tracking status of the player, wherein different player tracking statuses are associated with different quantities of entries in the drawing for the same or similar social media activities. In another such embodiment, the quantity of entries in the drawing is additionally or alternatively associated with a duration in which the social media activity occurred, wherein different durations are associated with different quantities of entries in a drawing.

It should be appreciated that in these embodiments, since one or more entries into one or more drawings, such as an entry into a drawing to win a progressive award, and one or more plays of one or more games of chance (and/or games of skill) may or may not result in an award for the player, such benefits are opportunities to obtain one or more benefits in association with the social media activity. That is, while such benefits have an average expected value (i.e., a theoretical value which is based on the awards available and the probability of obtaining any of such awards), since one or more random determinations subsequently occur in association with the determined benefit and an actual value of the determined benefit (i.e., the benefit associated with the determined benefit) is based on the results of such random determinations (wherein the actual value may be a lucrative value or a value of zero), these determined benefits may be viewed as opportunities to obtain a benefit.

In certain embodiments, the determined benefit includes a conditional award that the player becomes eligible for based on the satisfaction of one or more criteria. For example, if a player associated with a benefit of a conditional award places a wager on a play of a game at the gaming establishment while following a gaming establishment on two social media platforms, the gaming system determines that the criteria associated with the conditional award is satisfied and the conditional award vests (i.e., the award becomes available to the player). It should be appreciated that any suitable criteria associated with the gaming establishment, associated with an entity having a relationship with the gaming establishment or independent of the gaming establishment may be utilized to determine whether or not the player satisfies such criteria and thus becomes eligible to win the conditional award.

In certain embodiments, the determined benefit includes a quantity of player tracking points. In these embodiments, to entice a player to partake in social media activity associated with a gaming establishment, the gaming system determines a benefit of an additional quantity of player tracking points. In various embodiments, the determined benefit is based on the social media activity which occurred, wherein different social media activities are associated with different quantities of player tracking points. In certain additional or alternative embodiments, different periods of time over which

such social media activities occurred are associated with different quantities of player tracking points.

In certain embodiments, the determined benefit includes a player tracking point (or other comp) modifier applicable to a quantity of player tracking points (or other comps) subsequently earned by the player. In these embodiments, in exchange for a player participating in one or more social media activities associated with a gaming establishment, the gaming system determines a benefit of a player tracking point modifier which can be activated when the player next visits the gaming establishment (or otherwise plays an online game associated with earning player tracking points of the gaming establishment). In certain embodiments, the determined benefit additionally or alternatively includes a player tracking point (or other comps) modifier applicable to a quantity of player tracking points (or other comps) previously earned by the player. In these embodiments, in exchange for a player participating in one or more social media activities associated with a gaming establishment, the gaming system determines a benefit of a player tracking point modifier which can be activated against previously earned player tracking points (and/or subsequently earned player tracking points when the player next visits the gaming establishment (or otherwise plays an online game associated with earning player tracking points of the gaming establishment)). In certain embodiments, different social media activities are associated with different player tracking point modifiers. In certain additional or alternative embodiments, different periods of time over which such social media activities occurred are associated with different player tracking point modifiers.

In certain embodiments, the determined benefit includes a quantity of promotional credits usable to fund one or more plays of one or more games of chance (and/or games of skill). In certain other embodiments, the determined benefit additionally or alternatively includes a quantity of promotional credits usable to fund one or more plays of one or more online games of chance (and/or games of skill) accessible remote from the gaming establishment. In certain embodiments, different social media activities are associated with different quantities of promotional credits. In certain additional or alternative embodiments, different periods of time over which such social media activities occurred are associated with different quantities of promotional credits. It should be appreciated that while such promotional credits have an actual value (i.e., the average expected value of the game(s) played which are funded by such promotional credits), since the games played using such promotional credits may result in one or more awards different than the average expected value of such games, the player may ultimately realize a different valued benefit in exchange for participating in one or more social media activities associated with a gaming establishment. For example, if a player obtains a quantity of promotional credits in exchange for participating in one or more social media activities associated with a gaming establishment and the player subsequently wins a progressive award during a play of a game funded by such a quantity of promotional credits, the player has indirectly realized a benefit valued at the progressive award amount for participating in one or more social media activities associated with a gaming establishment.

In certain embodiments, the determined benefit includes a quantity of virtual credits usable for a play of a social or non-wagering game. In certain embodiments, different social media activities are associated with different quantities of virtual credits earned as benefits and usable for a play of a social or non-wagering game. In certain additional or

alternative embodiments, different periods of time over which the social media activities occurred are associated with different quantities of virtual credits usable for a play of a social or non-wagering game.

It should be appreciated that in these embodiments, since the conditional prize, the player tracking points, the promotional credits, the virtual credits, the player tracking point modifier and the feature(s) have static values, such benefits are associated with known benefits associated with participating in one or more social media activities associated with a gaming establishment (with or without the subsequent satisfaction of one or more conditions). That is, unlike certain benefits, such as an entry into a drawing or a play of a game of chance (and/or a game of skill), which may result in the player obtaining no value for participating in one or more social media activities associated with a gaming establishment (i.e., a zero value benefit) or which may result in the player obtaining a positive valued benefit for participating in one or more social media activities associated with a gaming establishment (and thus represent opportunities to obtain a benefit), other benefits, such as a quantity of player tracking points or a quantity of virtual credits will result in the player obtaining value (upon the satisfaction of zero, one or more conditions) (and thus represent benefits associated with participating in one or more social media activities associated with a gaming establishment).

In certain embodiments, the determined benefit includes a feature usable in association with a play of a game. That is, the determined benefit is associated with one or more plays of one or more games and a modification or activation to one or more game play features and/or an addition or unlocking of one or more game play features. In certain of these embodiments, the determined benefit includes altering or otherwise modifying one or more features, aspects or parameters of one or more subsequently played games. In these embodiments, a determined benefit includes any suitable feature which modifies any aspect of any game subsequently played by the player which is associated with the offered benefit. In various embodiments, one or more features employed as a determined benefit to modify one or more aspects of one or more such games subsequently played include, but are not limited to: a feature modifying one or more symbols available to be generated for a subsequent play of a game; a feature modifying one or more wild symbols available to be generated for a subsequent play of a game; a feature modifying a quantity of reels to be used for a subsequent play of a game; a feature modifying which of a plurality of reel are to be used for a subsequent play of a game; a feature modifying a deck of playing cards to be used for a subsequent play of a game; a feature modifying a quantity of playing cards to be used for a subsequent play of a game; a feature modifying a quantity of poker hands to be dealt for a subsequent play of a game; a book-end wild symbols feature; a stacked wild symbols feature; an expanding wild symbols feature; a retrigger symbol feature; an anti-terminator symbol feature; a locking reel feature, a locking symbol position feature; a modifier, such as a multiplier, feature; a feature modifying an amount of credits of a credit balance; a feature modifying an amount of promotional credits; a feature modifying a placed wager amount (e.g., a player placed a bet of \$1 which is treated by the EGM as a bet of \$2); a feature modifying a placed side wager amount; a feature modifying a rate of earning player tracking points; a feature modifying a rate of earning promotional credits; a feature modifying a rate of earning virtual credits; a feature modifying a number of wagered on paylines; a feature modifying a wager placed on one or more

paylines (or on one or more designated paylines); a feature modifying a number of ways to win wagered on; a feature modifying a wager placed on one or more ways to win (or on one or more designated ways to win); a feature modifying an average expected payback percentage of a subsequent play of a game; a feature modifying an average expected payout of a subsequent play of a game; a feature modifying one or more awards available; a feature modifying a range of awards available; a feature modifying a type of awards available; a feature modifying one or more progressive awards; a feature modifying which progressive awards are available to be won; a feature modifying one or more modifiers, such as multipliers, available; a feature modifying an activation of a reel (or a designated reel); a feature modifying an activation of a plurality of reels; a feature modifying a generated outcome (or a designated generated outcome); a feature modifying a generated outcome (or a designated generated outcome) associated with an award over a designated value; a feature modifying a generated outcome (or a designated generated outcome) on a designated payline; a feature modifying a generated outcome (or a designated generated outcome) in a scatter configuration; a feature modifying a winning way to win (or a designated winning way to win); a feature modifying a designated symbol or symbol combination; a feature modifying a generation of a designated symbol or symbol combination on a designated payline; a feature modifying a generation of a designated symbol or symbol combination in a scatter configuration; a feature modifying a triggering event of a play of a secondary or bonus game; a feature modifying an activation of a secondary or bonus display (such as an award generator); a feature modifying a quantity of activations of a secondary or bonus display (e.g., a feature modifying a quantity of spins of an award generator); a feature modifying a quantity of sections of a secondary or bonus display (e.g., a feature modifying a quantity of sections of an award generator); a feature modifying one or more awards of a secondary or bonus display; a feature modifying an activation of a community award generator; a feature modifying a quantity of activations of a community award generator; a feature modifying a quantity of sections of a community award generator; a feature modifying one or more awards of a community award generator; a feature modifying a generated outcome (or a designated generated outcome) in a secondary game; a feature modifying a quantity of picks in a selection game (e.g., provide a player four picks in a selection game otherwise associated with 3 picks); a feature modifying a quantity of offers in an offer and acceptance game; a feature modifying a quantity of moves in a trail game; a feature modifying an amount of free spins provided; a feature modifying a game terminating or ending condition; a feature modifying an availability of a secondary game; a feature modifying a theme of a game; and/or a feature modifying any game play feature associated with any play of any game disclosed herein.

It should be appreciated that providing one or more benefits in association with one or more players social media activities may result in a player obtaining one or more benefits after the player has left a gaming establishment. That is, since the social media activity may continue after the player is no longer located at the gaming establishment and since the player is provided one or more benefits in association with this social media activity, the player may obtain such benefits after the player has returned home or otherwise terminated their stay at the gaming establishment. In these embodiments, the gaming system communicates the benefit to the player via any suitable manner, such as through

telephone, e-mail, SMS or text messages, additional social media postings, mobile device application notification, and/or any other suitable medium.

In certain embodiments, the gaming system provides one or more benefits to the player independent of any subsequent return to the gaming establishment. In certain embodiments, the gaming system provides one or more benefits to the player dependent on the player remaining at the gaming establishment or subsequently returning to the gaming establishment. In one such embodiment, the gaming system provides the determined benefit to the player in the form of a voucher (e.g., a paper voucher or a virtual voucher) redeemable at a gaming establishment to obtain the determined benefit. In another such embodiment, the determined benefit is associated with the player remaining at the gaming establishment or subsequently returning to the gaming establishment.

It should be appreciated that in different embodiments, one or more of:

- i. whether a social media content distribution event occurs and/or a social media benefit triggering event occurs;
- ii. a type of social media content to distribute when a social media content distribution event occurs;
- iii. an amount of social media content to distribute when a social media content distribution event occurs;
- iv. when to distribute social media content when a social media content distribution event occurs;
- v. how to distribute social media content when a social media content distribution event occurs;
- vi. a type of benefit to provide if a social media benefit triggering event occurs;
- vii. an amount of a benefit to provide if a social media benefit triggering event occurs; and/or
- viii. any determination disclosed herein;

is/are predetermined, randomly determined, randomly determined based on one or more weighted percentages, determined based on a generated symbol or symbol combination, determined independent of a generated symbol or symbol combination, determined based on a random determination by the central controller, determined independent of a random determination by the central controller, determined based on a random determination at the gaming table component, determined independent of a random determination at the gaming table component, determined based on at least one play of at least one game, determined independent of at least one play of at least one game, determined based on a player's selection, determined independent of a player's selection, determined based on one or more side wagers placed, determined independent of one or more side wagers placed, determined based on the player's primary game wager, determined independent of the player's primary game wager, determined based on time (such as the time of day), determined independent of time (such as the time of day), determined based on an amount of coin-in accumulated in one or more pools, determined independent of an amount of coin-in accumulated in one or more pools, determined based on a status of the player (i.e., a player tracking status), determined independent of a status of the player (i.e., a player tracking status), determined based on one or more other determinations disclosed herein, determined independent of any other determination disclosed herein or determined based on any other suitable method or criteria.

Gaming Systems

The above-described embodiments of the present disclosure may be implemented in accordance with or in conjunc-

tion with one or more of a variety of different types of gaming systems, such as, but not limited to, those described below.

The present disclosure contemplates a variety of different gaming systems each having one or more of a plurality of different features, attributes, or characteristics. A "gaming system" as used herein refers to various configurations of: (a) one or more central servers, central controllers, or remote hosts; (b) one or more electronic gaming machines such as those located on a casino floor; and/or (c) one or more personal gaming devices, such as desktop computers, laptop computers, tablet computers or computing devices, personal digital assistants, mobile phones, and other mobile computing devices. Moreover, an electronic gaming machine ("EGM") as used herein refers to any suitable electronic gaming machine which enables a player to play, amongst any other games, a game of skill (or a game of partial skill), wherein the EGM comprises, but is not limited to: a slot machine, a video poker machine, a video lottery terminal, a terminal associated with an electronic table game, a video keno machine, a video bingo machine located on a casino floor, a sports betting terminal, or a kiosk, such as a sports betting kiosk.

In various embodiments, the gaming system of the present disclosure includes: (a) one or more electronic gaming machines in combination with one or more central servers, central controllers, or remote hosts; (b) one or more personal gaming devices in combination with one or more central servers, central controllers, or remote hosts; (c) one or more personal gaming devices in combination with one or more electronic gaming machines; (d) one or more personal gaming devices, one or more electronic gaming machines, and one or more central servers, central controllers, or remote hosts in combination with one another; (e) a single electronic gaming machine; (f) a plurality of electronic gaming machines in combination with one another; (g) a single personal gaming device; (h) a plurality of personal gaming devices in combination with one another; (i) a single central server, central controller, or remote host; and/or (j) a plurality of central servers, central controllers, or remote hosts in combination with one another.

For brevity and clarity and unless specifically stated otherwise, "EGM" as used herein represents one EGM or a plurality of EGMs, "personal gaming device" as used herein represents one personal gaming device or a plurality of personal gaming devices, and "central server, central controller, or remote host" as used herein represents one central server, central controller, or remote host or a plurality of central servers, central controllers, or remote hosts.

As noted above, in various embodiments, the gaming system includes an EGM (or personal gaming device) in combination with a central server, central controller, or remote host. In such embodiments, the EGM (or personal gaming device) is configured to communicate with the central server, central controller, or remote host through a data network or remote communication link. In certain such embodiments, the EGM (or personal gaming device) is configured to communicate with another EGM (or personal gaming device) through the same data network or remote communication link or through a different data network or remote communication link. For example, the gaming system includes a plurality of EGMs that are each configured to communicate with a central server, central controller, or remote host through a data network.

In certain embodiments in which the gaming system includes an EGM (or personal gaming device) in combination with a central server, central controller, or remote host,

the central server, central controller, or remote host is any suitable computing device (such as a server) that includes at least one processor and at least one memory device or data storage device. As further described herein, the EGM (or personal gaming device) includes at least one EGM (or personal gaming device) processor configured to transmit and receive data or signals representing events, messages, commands, or any other suitable information between the EGM (or personal gaming device) and the central server, central controller, or remote host. The at least one processor of that EGM (or personal gaming device) is configured to execute the events, messages, or commands represented by such data or signals in conjunction with the operation of the EGM (or personal gaming device). Moreover, the at least one processor of the central server, central controller, or remote host is configured to transmit and receive data or signals representing events, messages, commands, or any other suitable information between the central server, central controller, or remote host and the EGM (or personal gaming device). The at least one processor of the central server, central controller, or remote host is configured to execute the events, messages, or commands represented by such data or signals in conjunction with the operation of the central server, central controller, or remote host. One, more than one, or each of the functions of the central server, central controller, or remote host may be performed by the at least one processor of the EGM (or personal gaming device). Further, one, more than one, or each of the functions of the at least one processor of the EGM (or personal gaming device) may be performed by the at least one processor of the central server, central controller, or remote host.

In certain such embodiments, computerized instructions for controlling any games (such as any primary or base games and/or any secondary or bonus games) displayed by the EGM (or personal gaming device) are executed by the central server, central controller, or remote host. In such "thin client" embodiments, the central server, central controller, or remote host remotely controls any games (or other suitable interfaces) displayed by the EGM (or personal gaming device), and the EGM (or personal gaming device) is utilized to display such games (or suitable interfaces) and to receive one or more inputs or commands. In other such embodiments, computerized instructions for controlling any games displayed by the EGM (or personal gaming device) are communicated from the central server, central controller, or remote host to the EGM (or personal gaming device) and are stored in at least one memory device of the EGM (or personal gaming device). In such "thick client" embodiments, the at least one processor of the EGM (or personal gaming device) executes the computerized instructions to control any games (or other suitable interfaces) displayed by the EGM (or personal gaming device).

In various embodiments in which the gaming system includes a plurality of EGMs (or personal gaming devices), one or more of the EGMs (or personal gaming devices) are thin client EGMs (or personal gaming devices) and one or more of the EGMs (or personal gaming devices) are thick client EGMs (or personal gaming devices). In other embodiments in which the gaming system includes one or more EGMs (or personal gaming devices), certain functions of one or more of the EGMs (or personal gaming devices) are implemented in a thin client environment, and certain other functions of one or more of the EGMs (or personal gaming devices) are implemented in a thick client environment. In one such embodiment in which the gaming system includes an EGM (or personal gaming device) and a central server, central controller, or remote host, computerized instructions

for controlling any primary or base games displayed by the EGM (or personal gaming device) are communicated from the central server, central controller, or remote host to the EGM (or personal gaming device) in a thick client configuration, and computerized instructions for controlling any secondary or bonus games or other functions displayed by the EGM (or personal gaming device) are executed by the central server, central controller, or remote host in a thin client configuration.

In certain embodiments in which the gaming system includes: (a) an EGM (or personal gaming device) configured to communicate with a central server, central controller, or remote host through a data network; and/or (b) a plurality of EGMs (or personal gaming devices) configured to communicate with one another through a data network, the data network is a local area network (LAN) in which the EGMs (or personal gaming devices) are located substantially proximate to one another and/or the central server, central controller, or remote host. In one example, the EGMs (or personal gaming devices) and the central server, central controller, or remote host are located in a gaming establishment or a portion of a gaming establishment.

In other embodiments in which the gaming system includes: (a) an EGM (or personal gaming device) configured to communicate with a central server, central controller, or remote host through a data network; and/or (b) a plurality of EGMs (or personal gaming devices) configured to communicate with one another through a data network, the data network is a wide area network (WAN) in which one or more of the EGMs (or personal gaming devices) are not necessarily located substantially proximate to another one of the EGMs (or personal gaming devices) and/or the central server, central controller, or remote host. For example, one or more of the EGMs (or personal gaming devices) are located: (a) in an area of a gaming establishment different from an area of the gaming establishment in which the central server, central controller, or remote host is located; or (b) in a gaming establishment different from the gaming establishment in which the central server, central controller, or remote host is located. In another example, the central server, central controller, or remote host is not located within a gaming establishment in which the EGMs (or personal gaming devices) are located. In certain embodiments in which the data network is a WAN, the gaming system includes a central server, central controller, or remote host and an EGM (or personal gaming device) each located in a different gaming establishment in a same geographic area, such as a same city or a same state. Gaming systems in which the data network is a WAN are substantially identical to gaming systems in which the data network is a LAN, though the quantity of EGMs (or personal gaming devices) in such gaming systems may vary relative to one another.

In further embodiments in which the gaming system includes: (a) an EGM (or personal gaming device) configured to communicate with a central server, central controller, or remote host through a data network; and/or (b) a plurality of EGMs (or personal gaming devices) configured to communicate with one another through a data network, the data network is an internet (such as the Internet) or an intranet. In certain such embodiments, an Internet browser of the EGM (or personal gaming device) is usable to access an Internet game page from any location where an Internet connection is available. In one such embodiment, after the EGM (or personal gaming device) accesses the Internet game page, the central server, central controller, or remote host identifies a player before enabling that player to place any wagers on any plays of any wagering games. In one

example, the central server, central controller, or remote host identifies the player by requiring a player account of the player to be logged into via an input of a unique player name and password combination assigned to the player. The central server, central controller, or remote host may, however, identify the player in any other suitable manner, such as by validating a player tracking identification number associated with the player; by reading a player tracking card or other smart card inserted into a card reader (as described below); by validating a unique player identification number associated with the player by the central server, central controller, or remote host; or by identifying the EGM (or personal gaming device), such as by identifying the MAC address or the IP address of the Internet facilitator. In various embodiments, once the central server, central controller, or remote host identifies the player, the central server, central controller, or remote host enables placement of one or more wagers on one or more plays of one or more primary or base games and/or one or more secondary or bonus games, and displays those plays via the Internet browser of the EGM (or personal gaming device). Examples of implementations of Internet-based gaming are further described in U.S. Pat. No. 8,764,566, entitled "Internet Remote Game Server," and U.S. Pat. No. 8,147,334, entitled "Universal Game Server".

The central server, central controller, or remote host and the EGM (or personal gaming device) are configured to connect to the data network or remote communications link in any suitable manner. In various embodiments, such a connection is accomplished via: a conventional phone line or other data transmission line, a digital subscriber line (DSL), a T-1 line, a coaxial cable, a fiber optic cable, a wireless or wired routing device, a mobile communications network connection (such as a cellular network or mobile Internet network), or any other suitable medium. The expansion in the quantity of computing devices and the quantity and speed of Internet connections in recent years increases opportunities for players to use a variety of EGMs (or personal gaming devices) to play games from an ever-increasing quantity of remote sites. Additionally, the enhanced bandwidth of digital wireless communications may render such technology suitable for some or all communications, particularly if such communications are encrypted. Higher data transmission speeds may be useful for enhancing the sophistication and response of the display and interaction with players.

EGM Components

FIG. 3 is a block diagram of an example EGM **1000** and FIGS. 4A and 4B include two different example EGMs **2000a** and **2000b**. The EGMs **1000**, **2000a**, and **2000b** are merely example EGMs, and different EGMs may be implemented using different combinations of the components shown in the EGMs **1000**, **2000a**, and **2000b**. Although the below refers to EGMs, in various embodiments personal gaming devices (such as personal gaming device **2000c** of FIG. 4C) may include some or all of the below components.

In these embodiments, the EGM **1000** includes a master gaming controller **1012** configured to communicate with and to operate with a plurality of peripheral devices **1022**.

The master gaming controller **1012** includes at least one processor **1010**. The at least one processor **1010** is any suitable processing device or set of processing devices, such as a microprocessor, a microcontroller-based platform, a suitable integrated circuit, or one or more application-specific integrated circuits (ASICs), configured to execute software enabling various configuration and reconfiguration

tasks, such as: (1) communicating with a remote source (such as a server that stores authentication information or game information) via a communication interface **1006** of the master gaming controller **1012**; (2) converting signals read by an interface to a format corresponding to that used by software or memory of the EGM; (3) accessing memory to configure or reconfigure game parameters in the memory according to indicia read from the EGM; (4) communicating with interfaces and the peripheral devices **1022** (such as input/output devices); and/or (5) controlling the peripheral devices **1022**. In certain embodiments, one or more components of the master gaming controller **1012** (such as the at least one processor **1010**) reside within a housing of the EGM (described below), while in other embodiments at least one component of the master gaming controller **1012** resides outside of the housing of the EGM.

The master gaming controller **1012** also includes at least one memory device **1016**, which includes: (1) volatile memory (e.g., RAM **1009**, which can include non-volatile RAM, magnetic RAM, ferroelectric RAM, and any other suitable forms); (2) non-volatile memory **1019** (e.g., disk memory, FLASH memory, EPROMs, EEPROMs, memristor-based non-volatile solid-state memory, etc.); (3) unalterable memory (e.g., EPROMs **1008**); (4) read-only memory; and/or (5) a secondary memory storage device **1015**, such as a non-volatile memory device, configured to store gaming software related information (the gaming software related information and the memory may be used to store various audio files and games not currently being used and invoked in a configuration or reconfiguration). Any other suitable magnetic, optical, and/or semiconductor memory may operate in conjunction with the EGM disclosed herein. In certain embodiments, the at least one memory device **1016** resides within the housing of the EGM (described below), while in other embodiments at least one component of the at least one memory device **1016** resides outside of the housing of the EGM. In these embodiments, any combination of one or more computer readable media may be utilized. The computer readable media may be a computer readable signal medium or a computer readable storage medium. A computer readable storage medium may be, for example, but not limited to, an electronic, magnetic, optical, electromagnetic, or semiconductor system, apparatus, or device, or any suitable combination of the foregoing. More specific examples (a non-exhaustive list) of the computer readable storage medium would include the following: a portable computer diskette, a hard disk, a random access memory (RAM), a read-only memory (ROM), an erasable programmable read-only memory (EPROM or Flash memory), an appropriate optical fiber with a repeater, a portable compact disc read-only memory (CD-ROM), an optical storage device, a magnetic storage device, or any suitable combination of the foregoing. In the context of this document, a computer readable storage medium may be any tangible medium that can contain, or store a program for use by or in connection with an instruction execution system, apparatus, or device.

A computer readable signal medium may include a propagated data signal with computer readable program code embodied therein, for example, in baseband or as part of a carrier wave. Such a propagated signal may take any of a variety of forms, including, but not limited to, electromagnetic, optical, or any suitable combination thereof. A computer readable signal medium may be any computer readable medium that is not a computer readable storage medium and that can communicate, propagate, or transport a program for use by or in connection with an instruction execution system, apparatus, or device. Program code

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embodied on a computer readable signal medium may be transmitted using any appropriate medium, including but not limited to wireless, wireline, optical fiber cable, RF, etc., or any suitable combination of the foregoing.

The at least one memory device **1016** is configured to store, for example: (1) configuration software **1014**, such as all the parameters and settings for a game playable on the EGM; (2) associations **1018** between configuration indicia read from an EGM with one or more parameters and settings; (3) communication protocols configured to enable the at least one processor **1010** to communicate with the peripheral devices **1022**; and/or (4) communication transport protocols (such as TCP/IP, USB, Firewire, IEEE1394, Bluetooth, IEEE 802.11x (IEEE 802.11 standards), hipervlan/2, HomeRF, etc.) configured to enable the EGM to communicate with local and non-local devices using such protocols. In one implementation, the master gaming controller **1012** communicates with other devices using a serial communication protocol. A few non-limiting examples of serial communication protocols that other devices, such as peripherals (e.g., a bill validator or a ticket printer), may use to communicate with the master game controller **1012** include USB, RS-232, and Netplex (a proprietary protocol developed by IGT).

As will be appreciated by one skilled in the art, aspects of the present disclosure may be illustrated and described herein in any of a number of patentable classes or context including any new and useful process, machine, manufacture, or composition of matter, or any new and useful improvement thereof. Accordingly, aspects of the present disclosure may be implemented entirely hardware, entirely software (including firmware, resident software, microcode, etc.) or combining software and hardware implementation that may all generally be referred to herein as a “circuit,” “module,” “component,” or “system.” Furthermore, aspects of the present disclosure may take the form of a computer program product embodied in one or more computer readable media having computer readable program code embodied thereon.

Computer program code for carrying out operations for aspects of the present disclosure may be written in any combination of one or more programming languages, including an object oriented programming language such as Java, Scala, Smalltalk, Eiffel, JADE, Emerald, C++, C#, VB.NET, Python or the like, conventional procedural programming languages, such as the “C” programming language, Visual Basic, Fortran 2003, Perl, COBOL 2002, PHP, ABAP, dynamic programming languages such as Python, Ruby and Groovy, or other programming languages. The program code may execute entirely on the player’s computer, partly on the player’s computer, as a stand-alone software package, partly on the player’s computer and partly on a remote computer or entirely on the remote computer or server. In the latter scenario, the remote computer may be connected to the player’s computer through any type of network, including a local area network (LAN) or a wide area network (WAN), or the connection may be made to an external computer (for example, through the Internet using an Internet Service Provider) or in a cloud computing environment or offered as a service such as a Software as a Service (SaaS).

Aspects of the present disclosure are described herein with reference to flowchart illustrations and/or block diagrams of methods, apparatuses (systems) and computer program products according to embodiments of the disclosure. It will be understood that each block of the flowchart illustrations and/or block diagrams, and combinations of

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blocks in the flowchart illustrations and/or block diagrams, can be implemented by computer program instructions. These computer program instructions may be provided to a processor of a general purpose computer, special purpose computer, or other programmable data processing apparatus to produce a machine, such that the instructions, which execute via the processor of the computer or other programmable instruction execution apparatus, create a mechanism for implementing the functions/acts specified in the flowchart and/or block diagram block or blocks.

These computer program instructions may also be stored in a computer readable medium that when executed can direct a computer, other programmable data processing apparatus, or other devices to function in a particular manner, such that the instructions when stored in the computer readable medium produce an article of manufacture including instructions which when executed, cause a computer to implement the function/act specified in the flowchart and/or block diagram block or blocks. The computer program instructions may also be loaded onto a computer, other programmable instruction execution apparatus, or other devices to cause a series of operational steps to be performed on the computer, other programmable apparatuses or other devices to produce a computer implemented process such that the instructions which execute on the computer or other programmable apparatus provide processes for implementing the functions/acts specified in the flowchart and/or block diagram block or blocks.

In certain embodiments, the at least one memory device **1016** is configured to store program code and instructions executable by the at least one processor of the EGM to control the EGM. The at least one memory device **1016** of the EGM also stores other operating data, such as image data, event data, input data, random number generators (RNGs) or pseudo-RNGs, payable data or information, and/or applicable game rules that relate to the play of one or more games on the EGM. In various embodiments, part or all of the program code and/or the operating data described above is stored in at least one detachable or removable memory device including, but not limited to, a cartridge, a disk, a CD ROM, a DVD, a USB memory device, or any other suitable non-transitory computer readable medium. In certain such embodiments, an operator (such as a gaming establishment operator) and/or a player uses such a removable memory device in an EGM to implement at least part of the present disclosure. In other embodiments, part or all of the program code and/or the operating data is downloaded to the at least one memory device of the EGM through any suitable data network described above (such as an Internet or intranet).

The at least one memory device **1016** also stores a plurality of device drivers **1042**. Examples of different types of device drivers include device drivers for EGM components and device drivers for the peripheral components **1022**. Typically, the device drivers **1042** utilize various communication protocols that enable communication with a particular physical device. The device driver abstracts the hardware implementation of that device. For example, a device driver may be written for each type of card reader that could potentially be connected to the EGM. Non-limiting examples of communication protocols used to implement the device drivers include Netplex, USB, Serial, Ethernet **175**, Firewire, I/O debouncer, direct memory map, serial, PCI, parallel, RF, Bluetooth™, near-field communications (e.g., using near-field magnetics), 802.11 (WiFi), etc. In one embodiment, when one type of a particular device is exchanged for another type of the particular device, the at

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least one processor of the EGM loads the new device driver from the at least one memory device to enable communication with the new device. For instance, one type of card reader in the EGM can be replaced with a second different type of card reader when device drivers for both card readers are stored in the at least one memory device.

In certain embodiments, the software units stored in the at least one memory device **1016** can be upgraded as needed. For instance, when the at least one memory device **1016** is a hard drive, new games, new game options, new parameters, new settings for existing parameters, new settings for new parameters, new device drivers, and new communication protocols can be uploaded to the at least one memory device **1016** from the master game controller **1012** or from some other external device. As another example, when the at least one memory device **1016** includes a CD/DVD drive including a CD/DVD configured to store game options, parameters, and settings, the software stored in the at least one memory device **1016** can be upgraded by replacing a first CD/DVD with a second CD/DVD. In yet another example, when the at least one memory device **1016** uses flash memory **1019** or EPROM **1008** units configured to store games, game options, parameters, and settings, the software stored in the flash and/or EPROM memory units can be upgraded by replacing one or more memory units with new memory units that include the upgraded software. In another embodiment, one or more of the memory devices, such as the hard drive, may be employed in a game software download process from a remote software server.

In some embodiments, the at least one memory device **1016** also stores authentication and/or validation components **1044** configured to authenticate/validate specified EGM components and/or information, such as hardware components, software components, firmware components, peripheral device components, player input device components, information received from one or more player input devices, information stored in the at least one memory device **1016**, etc. Examples of various authentication and/or validation components are described in U.S. Pat. No. 6,620,047, entitled "Electronic Gaming Apparatus Having Authentication Data Sets".

In certain embodiments, the peripheral devices **1022** include several device interfaces, such as: (1) at least one output device **1020** including at least one display device **1035**; (2) at least one input device **1030** (which may include contact and/or non-contact interfaces); (3) at least one transponder **1054**; (4) at least one wireless communication component **1056**; (5) at least one wired/wireless power distribution component **1058**; (6) at least one sensor **1060**; (7) at least one data preservation component **1062**; (8) at least one motion/gesture analysis and interpretation component **1064**; (9) at least one motion detection component **1066**; (10) at least one portable power source **1068**; (11) at least one geolocation module **1076**; (12) at least one player identification module **1077**; (13) at least one player/device tracking module **1078**; and (14) at least one information filtering module **1079**.

The at least one output device **1020** includes at least one display device **1035** configured to display any game(s) displayed by the EGM and any suitable information associated with such game(s). In certain embodiments, the display devices are connected to or mounted on a housing of the EGM (described below). In various embodiments, the display devices serve as digital glass configured to advertise certain games or other aspects of the gaming establishment in which the EGM is located. In various embodiments, the EGM includes one or more of the following display devices:

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(a) a central display device; (b) a player tracking display configured to display various information regarding a player's player tracking status (as described below); (c) a secondary or upper display device in addition to the central display device and the player tracking display; (d) a credit display configured to display a current quantity of credits, amount of cash, account balance, or the equivalent; and (e) a bet display configured to display an amount wagered for one or more plays of one or more games. The example EGM **2000a** illustrated in FIG. 4A includes a central display device **2116**, a player tracking display **2140**, a credit display **2120**, and a bet display **2122**. The example EGM **2000b** illustrated in FIG. 4B includes a central display device **2116**, an upper display device **2118**, a player tracking display **2140**, a credit display **2120**, and a bet display **2122**.

In various embodiments, the display devices include, without limitation: a monitor, a television display, a plasma display, a liquid crystal display (LCD), a display based on light emitting diodes (LEDs), a display based on a plurality of organic light-emitting diodes (OLEDs), a display based on polymer light-emitting diodes (PLEDs), a display based on a plurality of surface-conduction electron-emitters (SEDs), a display including a projected and/or reflected image, or any other suitable electronic device or display mechanism. In certain embodiments, as described above, the display device includes a touch-screen with an associated touch-screen controller. The display devices may be of any suitable sizes, shapes, and configurations.

The display devices of the EGM are configured to display one or more game and/or non-game images, symbols, and indicia. In certain embodiments, the display devices of the EGM are configured to display any suitable visual representation or exhibition of the movement of objects; dynamic lighting; video images; images of people, characters, places, things, and faces of cards; and the like. In certain embodiments, the display devices of the EGM are configured to display one or more video reels, one or more video wheels, and/or one or more video dice. In other embodiments, certain of the displayed images, symbols, and indicia are in mechanical form. That is, in these embodiments, the display device includes any electromechanical device, such as one or more rotatable wheels, one or more reels, and/or one or more dice, configured to display at least one or a plurality of game or other suitable images, symbols, or indicia.

In various embodiments, the at least one output device **1020** includes a payout device. In these embodiments, after the EGM receives an actuation of a cashout device (described below), the EGM causes the payout device to provide a payment to the player. In one embodiment, the payout device is one or more of: (a) a ticket printer and dispenser configured to print and dispense a ticket or credit slip associated with a monetary value, wherein the ticket or credit slip may be redeemed for its monetary value via a cashier, a kiosk, or other suitable redemption system; (b) a bill dispenser configured to dispense paper currency; (c) a coin dispenser configured to dispense coins or tokens (such as into a coin payout tray); and (d) any suitable combination thereof. The example EGMs **2000a** and **2000b** illustrated in FIGS. 4A and 4B each include a ticket printer and dispenser **2136**. Examples of ticket-in ticket-out (TITO) technology are described in U.S. Pat. No. 5,429,361, entitled "Gaming Machine Information, Communication and Display System"; U.S. Pat. No. 5,470,079, entitled "Gaming Machine Accounting and Monitoring System"; U.S. Pat. No. 5,265,874, entitled "Cashless Gaming Apparatus and Method"; U.S. Pat. No. 6,729,957, entitled "Gaming Method and Host Computer with Ticket-In/Ticket-Out Capability"; U.S. Pat.

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No. 6,729,958, entitled "Gaming System with Ticket-In/Ticket-Out Capability"; U.S. Pat. No. 6,736,725, entitled "Gaming Method and Host Computer with Ticket-In/Ticket-Out Capability"; U.S. Pat. No. 7,275,991, entitled "Slot Machine with Ticket-In/Ticket-Out Capability"; and U.S. Pat. No. 6,048,269, entitled "Coinless Slot Machine System and Method".

In certain embodiments, rather than dispensing bills, coins, or a physical ticket having a monetary value to the player following receipt of an actuation of the cashout device, the payout device is configured to cause a payment to be provided to the player in the form of an electronic funds transfer, such as via a direct deposit into a bank account, a casino account, or a prepaid account of the player; via a transfer of funds onto an electronically recordable identification card or smart card of the player; or via sending a virtual ticket having a monetary value to an electronic device of the player. Examples of providing payment using virtual tickets are described in U.S. Pat. No. 8,613,659, entitled "Virtual Ticket-In and Ticket-Out on a Gaming Machine".

While any credit balances, any wagers, any values, and any awards are described herein as amounts of monetary credits or currency, one or more of such credit balances, such wagers, such values, and such awards may be for non-monetary credits, promotional credits, of player tracking points or credits.

In certain embodiments, the at least one output device **1020** is a sound generating device controlled by one or more sound cards. In one such embodiment, the sound generating device includes one or more speakers or other sound generating hardware and/or software configured to generate sounds, such as by playing music for any games or by playing music for other modes of the EGM, such as an attract mode. The example EGMs **2000a** and **2000b** illustrated in FIGS. 4A and 4B each include a plurality of speakers **2150**. In another such embodiment, the EGM provides dynamic sounds coupled with attractive multimedia images displayed on one or more of the display devices to provide an audio-visual representation or to otherwise display full-motion video with sound to attract players to the EGM. In certain embodiments, the EGM displays a sequence of audio and/or visual attraction messages during idle periods to attract potential players to the EGM. The videos may be customized to provide any appropriate information.

The at least one input device **1030** may include any suitable device that enables an input signal to be produced and received by the at least one processor **1010** of the EGM.

In one embodiment, the at least one input device **1030** includes a payment device configured to communicate with the at least one processor of the EGM to fund the EGM. In certain embodiments, the payment device includes one or more of: (a) a bill acceptor into which paper money is inserted to fund the EGM; (b) a ticket acceptor into which a ticket or a voucher is inserted to fund the EGM; (c) a coin slot into which coins or tokens are inserted to fund the EGM; (d) a reader or a validator for credit cards, debit cards, or credit slips into which a credit card, debit card, or credit slip is inserted to fund the EGM; (e) a player identification card reader into which a player identification card is inserted to fund the EGM; or (f) any suitable combination thereof. The example EGMs **2000a** and **2000b** illustrated in FIGS. 4A and 4B each include a combined bill and ticket acceptor **2128** and a coin slot **2126**.

In one embodiment, the at least one input device **1030** includes a payment device configured to enable the EGM to

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be funded via an electronic funds transfer, such as a transfer of funds from a bank account. In another embodiment, the EGM includes a payment device configured to communicate with a mobile device of a player, such as a mobile phone, a radio frequency identification tag, or any other suitable wired or wireless device, to retrieve relevant information associated with that player to fund the EGM. Examples of funding an EGM via communication between the EGM and a mobile device (such as a mobile phone) of a player are described in U.S. Patent Application Publication No. 2013/0344942, entitled "Avatar as Security Measure for Mobile Device Use with Electronic Gaming Machine". When the EGM is funded, the at least one processor determines the amount of funds entered and displays the corresponding amount on a credit display or any other suitable display as described below.

In certain embodiments, the at least one input device **1030** includes at least one wagering or betting device. In various embodiments, the one or more wagering or betting devices are each: (1) a mechanical button supported by the housing of the EGM (such as a hard key or a programmable soft key), or (2) an icon displayed on a display device of the EGM (described below) that is actuatable via a touch screen of the EGM (described below) or via use of a suitable input device of the EGM (such as a mouse or a joystick). One such wagering or betting device is as a maximum wager or bet device that, when actuated, causes the EGM to place a maximum wager on a play of a game. Another such wagering or betting device is a repeat bet device that, when actuated, causes the EGM to place a wager that is equal to the previously-placed wager on a play of a game. A further such wagering or betting device is a bet one device that, when actuated, causes the EGM to increase the wager by one credit. Generally, upon actuation of one of the wagering or betting devices, the quantity of credits displayed in a credit meter (described below) decreases by the amount of credits wagered, while the quantity of credits displayed in a bet display (described below) increases by the amount of credits wagered.

In various embodiments, the at least one input device **1030** includes at least one game play activation device. In various embodiments, the one or more game play initiation devices are each: (1) a mechanical button supported by the housing of the EGM (such as a hard key or a programmable soft key), or (2) an icon displayed on a display device of the EGM (described below) that is actuatable via a touch screen of the EGM (described below) or via use of a suitable input device of the EGM (such as a mouse or a joystick). After a player appropriately funds the EGM and places a wager, the EGM activates the game play activation device to enable the player to actuate the game play activation device to initiate a play of a game on the EGM (or another suitable sequence of events associated with the EGM). After the EGM receives an actuation of the game play activation device, the EGM initiates the play of the game. The example EGMs **2000a** and **2000b** illustrated in FIGS. 4A and 4B each include a game play activation device in the form of a game play initiation button **2132**. In other embodiments, the EGM begins game play automatically upon appropriate funding rather than upon utilization of the game play activation device.

In other embodiments, the at least one input device **1030** includes a cashout device. In various embodiments, the cashout device is: (1) a mechanical button supported by the housing of the EGM (such as a hard key or a programmable soft key), or (2) an icon displayed on a display device of the EGM (described below) that is actuatable via a touch screen

of the EGM (described below) or via use of a suitable input device of the EGM (such as a mouse or a joystick). When the EGM receives an actuation of the cashout device from a player and the player has a positive (i.e., greater-than-zero) credit balance, the EGM initiates a payout associated with the player's credit balance. The example EGMs **2000a** and **2000b** illustrated in FIGS. 4A and 4B each include a cashout device in the form of a cashout button **2134**.

In various embodiments, the at least one input device **1030** includes a plurality of buttons that are programmable by the EGM operator to, when actuated, cause the EGM to perform particular functions. For instance, such buttons may be hard keys, programmable soft keys, or icons icon displayed on a display device of the EGM (described below) that are actuatable via a touch screen of the EGM (described below) or via use of a suitable input device of the EGM (such as a mouse or a joystick). The example EGMs **2000a** and **2000b** illustrated in FIGS. 4A and 4B each include a plurality of such buttons **2130**.

In certain embodiments, the at least one input device **1030** includes a touch-screen coupled to a touch-screen controller or other touch-sensitive display overlay to enable interaction with any images displayed on a display device (as described below). One such input device is a conventional touch-screen button panel. The touch-screen and the touch-screen controller are connected to a video controller. In these embodiments, signals are input to the EGM by touching the touch screen at the appropriate locations.

In embodiments including a player tracking system, as further described below, the at least one input device **1030** includes a card reader in communication with the at least one processor of the EGM. The example EGMs **2000a** and **2000b** illustrated in FIGS. 4A and 4B each include a card reader **2138**. The card reader is configured to read a player identification card inserted into the card reader.

The at least one wireless communication component **1056** includes one or more communication interfaces having different architectures and utilizing a variety of protocols, such as (but not limited to) 802.11 (WiFi); 802.15 (including Bluetooth™); 802.16 (WiMax); 802.22; cellular standards such as CDMA, CDMA2000, and WCDMA; Radio Frequency (e.g., RFID); infrared; and Near Field Magnetic communication protocols. The at least one wireless communication component **1056** transmits electrical, electro-magnetic, or optical signals that carry digital data streams or analog signals representing various types of information.

The at least one wired/wireless power distribution component **1058** includes components or devices that are configured to provide power to other devices. For example, in one embodiment, the at least one power distribution component **1058** includes a magnetic induction system that is configured to provide wireless power to one or more player input devices near the EGM. In one embodiment, a player input device docking region is provided, and includes a power distribution component that is configured to recharge a player input device without requiring metal-to-metal contact. In one embodiment, the at least one power distribution component **1058** is configured to distribute power to one or more internal components of the EGM, such as one or more rechargeable power sources (e.g., rechargeable batteries) located at the EGM.

In certain embodiments, the at least one sensor **1060** includes at least one of: optical sensors, pressure sensors, RF sensors, infrared sensors, image sensors, thermal sensors, and biometric sensors. The at least one sensor **1060** may be used for a variety of functions, such as: detecting movements and/or gestures of various objects within a predeter-

mined proximity to the EGM; detecting the presence and/or identity of various persons (e.g., players, casino employees, etc.), devices (e.g., player input devices), and/or systems within a predetermined proximity to the EGM.

The at least one data preservation component **1062** is configured to detect or sense one or more events and/or conditions that, for example, may result in damage to the EGM and/or that may result in loss of information associated with the EGM. Additionally, the data preservation system **1062** may be operable to initiate one or more appropriate action(s) in response to the detection of such events/conditions.

The at least one motion/gesture analysis and interpretation component **1064** is configured to analyze and/or interpret information relating to detected player movements and/or gestures to determine appropriate player input information relating to the detected player movements and/or gestures. For example, in one embodiment, the at least one motion/gesture analysis and interpretation component **1064** is configured to perform one or more of the following functions: analyze the detected gross motion or gestures of a player; interpret the player's motion or gestures (e.g., in the context of a casino game being played) to identify instructions or input from the player; utilize the interpreted instructions/input to advance the game state; etc. In other embodiments, at least a portion of these additional functions may be implemented at a remote system or device.

The at least one portable power source **1068** enables the EGM to operate in a mobile environment. For example, in one embodiment, the EGM **300** includes one or more rechargeable batteries.

The at least one geolocation module **1076** is configured to acquire geolocation information from one or more remote sources and use the acquired geolocation information to determine information relating to a relative and/or absolute position of the EGM. For example, in one implementation, the at least one geolocation module **1076** is configured to receive GPS signal information for use in determining the position or location of the EGM. In another implementation, the at least one geolocation module **1076** is configured to receive multiple wireless signals from multiple remote devices (e.g., EGMs, servers, wireless access points, etc.) and use the signal information to compute position/location information relating to the position or location of the EGM.

The at least one player identification module **1077** is configured to determine the identity of the current player or current owner of the EGM. For example, in one embodiment, the current player is required to perform a login process at the EGM in order to access one or more features. Alternatively, the EGM is configured to automatically determine the identity of the current player based on one or more external signals, such as an RFID tag or badge worn by the current player and that provides a wireless signal to the EGM that is used to determine the identity of the current player. In at least one embodiment, various security features are incorporated into the EGM to prevent unauthorized players from accessing confidential or sensitive information.

The at least one information filtering module **1079** is configured to perform filtering (e.g., based on specified criteria) of selected information to be displayed at one or more displays **1035** of the EGM.

In various embodiments, the EGM includes a plurality of communication ports configured to enable the at least one processor of the EGM to communicate with and to operate with external peripherals, such as: accelerometers, arcade sticks, bar code readers, bill validators, biometric input devices, bonus devices, button panels, card readers, coin

dispensers, coin hoppers, display screens or other displays or video sources, expansion buses, information panels, key-pads, lights, mass storage devices, microphones, motion sensors, motors, printers, reels, SCSI ports, solenoids, speakers, thumbsticks, ticket readers, touch screens, track-balls, touchpads, wheels, and wireless communication devices. U.S. Pat. No. 7,290,072 describes a variety of EGMs including one or more communication ports that enable the EGMs to communicate and operate with one or more external peripherals.

As generally described above, in certain embodiments, such as the example EGMs **2000a** and **2000b** illustrated in FIGS. 4A and 4B, the EGM has a support structure, housing, or cabinet that provides support for a plurality of the input devices and the output devices of the EGM. Further, the EGM is configured such that a player may operate it while standing or sitting. In various embodiments, the EGM is positioned on a base or stand, or is configured as a pub-style tabletop game (not shown) that a player may operate typically while sitting. As illustrated by the different example EGMs **2000a** and **2000b** shown in FIGS. 4A and 4B, EGMs may have varying housing and display configurations.

In certain embodiments, the EGM is a device that has obtained approval from a regulatory gaming commission, and in other embodiments, the EGM is a device that has not obtained approval from a regulatory gaming commission.

The EGMs described above are merely three examples of different types of EGMs. Certain of these example EGMs may include one or more elements that may not be included in all gaming systems, and these example EGMs may not include one or more elements that are included in other gaming systems. For example, certain EGMs include a coin acceptor while others do not.

Operation of Primary or Base Games and/or Secondary or Bonus Games

In various embodiments, an EGM may be implemented in one of a variety of different configurations. In various embodiments, the EGM may be implemented as one of: (a) a dedicated EGM in which computerized game programs executable by the EGM for controlling any primary or base games (referred to herein as “primary games”) and/or any secondary or bonus games or other functions (referred to herein as “secondary games”) displayed by the EGM are provided with the EGM before delivery to a gaming establishment or before being provided to a player; and (b) a changeable EGM in which computerized game programs executable by the EGM for controlling any primary games and/or secondary games displayed by the EGM are downloadable or otherwise transferred to the EGM through a data network or remote communication link; from a USB drive, flash memory card, or other suitable memory device; or in any other suitable manner after the EGM is physically located in a gaming establishment or after the EGM is provided to a player.

As generally explained above, in various embodiments in which the gaming system includes a central server, central controller, or remote host and a changeable EGM, the at least one memory device of the central server, central controller, or remote host stores different game programs and instructions executable by the at least one processor of the changeable EGM to control one or more primary games and/or secondary games displayed by the changeable EGM. More specifically, each such executable game program represents a different game or a different type of game that the at least one changeable EGM is configured to operate. In one example, certain of the game programs are executable by the changeable EGM to operate games having the same or

substantially the same game play but different paytables. In different embodiments, each executable game program is associated with a primary game, a secondary game, or both. In certain embodiments, an executable game program is executable by the at least one processor of the at least one changeable EGM as a secondary game to be played simultaneously with a play of a primary game (which may be downloaded to or otherwise stored on the at least one changeable EGM), or vice versa.

In operation of such embodiments, the central server, central controller, or remote host is configured to communicate one or more of the stored executable game programs to the at least one processor of the changeable EGM. In different embodiments, a stored executable game program is communicated or delivered to the at least one processor of the changeable EGM by: (a) embedding the executable game program in a device or a component (such as a microchip to be inserted into the changeable EGM); (b) writing the executable game program onto a disc or other media; or (c) uploading or streaming the executable game program over a data network (such as a dedicated data network). After the executable game program is communicated from the central server, central controller, or remote host to the changeable EGM, the at least one processor of the changeable EGM executes the executable game program to enable the primary game and/or the secondary game associated with that executable game program to be played using the display device(s) and/or the input device(s) of the changeable EGM. That is, when an executable game program is communicated to the at least one processor of the changeable EGM, the at least one processor of the changeable EGM changes the game or the type of game that may be played using the changeable EGM.

In certain embodiments, the gaming system randomly determines any game outcome(s) (such as a win outcome) and/or award(s) (such as a quantity of credits to award for the win outcome) for a play of a primary game and/or a play of a secondary game based on probability data. In certain such embodiments, this random determination is provided through utilization of an RNG, such as a true RNG or a pseudo RNG, or any other suitable randomization process. In one such embodiment, each game outcome or award is associated with a probability, and the gaming system generates the game outcome(s) and/or the award(s) to be provided based on the associated probabilities. In these embodiments, since the gaming system generates game outcomes and/or awards randomly or based on one or more probability calculations, there is no certainty that the gaming system will ever provide any specific game outcome and/or award.

In certain embodiments, the gaming system maintains one or more predetermined pools or sets of predetermined game outcomes and/or awards. In certain such embodiments, upon generation or receipt of a game outcome and/or award request, the gaming system independently selects one of the predetermined game outcomes and/or awards from the one or more pools or sets. The gaming system flags or marks the selected game outcome and/or award as used. Once a game outcome or an award is flagged as used, it is prevented from further selection from its respective pool or set; that is, the gaming system does not select that game outcome or award upon another game outcome and/or award request. The gaming system provides the selected game outcome and/or award. Examples of this type of award evaluation are described in U.S. Pat. No. 7,470,183, entitled “Finite Pool Gaming Method and Apparatus”; U.S. Pat. No. 7,563,163, entitled “Gaming Device Including Outcome Pools for Providing Game Outcomes”; U.S. Pat. No. 7,833,092, entitled

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“Method and System for Compensating for Player Choice in a Game of Chance”; U.S. Pat. No. 8,070,579, entitled “Bingo System with Downloadable Common Patterns”; and U.S. Pat. No. 8,398,472, entitled “Central Determination Poker Game”.

In certain embodiments, the gaming system determines a predetermined game outcome and/or award based on the results of a bingo, keno, or lottery game. In certain such embodiments, the gaming system utilizes one or more bingo, keno, or lottery games to determine the predetermined game outcome and/or award provided for a primary game and/or a secondary game. The gaming system is provided or associated with a bingo card. Each bingo card consists of a matrix or array of elements, wherein each element is designated with separate indicia. After a bingo card is provided, the gaming system randomly selects or draws a plurality of the elements. As each element is selected, a determination is made as to whether the selected element is present on the bingo card. If the selected element is present on the bingo card, that selected element on the provided bingo card is marked or flagged. This process of selecting elements and marking any selected elements on the provided bingo cards continues until one or more predetermined patterns are marked on one or more of the provided bingo cards. After one or more predetermined patterns are marked on one or more of the provided bingo cards, game outcome and/or award is determined based, at least in part, on the selected elements on the provided bingo cards. Examples of this type of award determination are described in U.S. Pat. No. 7,753,774, entitled “Using Multiple Bingo Cards to Represent Multiple Slot Paylines and Other Class III Game Options”; U.S. Pat. No. 7,731,581, entitled “Multi-Player Bingo Game with Multiple Alternative Outcome Displays”; U.S. Pat. No. 7,955,170, entitled “Providing Non-Bingo Outcomes for a Bingo Game”; U.S. Pat. No. 8,070,579, entitled “Bingo System with Downloadable Common Patterns”; and U.S. Pat. No. 8,500,538, entitled “Bingo Gaming System and Method for Providing Multiple Outcomes from Single Bingo Pattern”.

In certain embodiments in which the gaming system includes a central server, central controller, or remote host and an EGM, the EGM is configured to communicate with the central server, central controller, or remote host for monitoring purposes only. In such embodiments, the EGM determines the game outcome(s) and/or award(s) to be provided in any of the manners described above, and the central server, central controller, or remote host monitors the activities and events occurring on the EGM. In one such embodiment, the gaming system includes a real-time or online accounting and gaming information system configured to communicate with the central server, central controller, or remote host. In this embodiment, the accounting and gaming information system includes: (a) a player database configured to store player profiles, (b) a player tracking module configured to track players (as described below), and (c) a credit system configured to provide automated transactions. Examples of such accounting systems are described in U.S. Pat. No. 6,913,534, entitled “Gaming Machine Having a Lottery Game and Capability for Integration with Gaming Device Accounting System and Player Tracking System,” and U.S. Pat. No. 8,597,116, entitled “Virtual Player Tracking and Related Services”.

As noted above, in various embodiments, the gaming system includes one or more executable game programs executable by at least one processor of the gaming system to provide one or more primary games and one or more secondary games. The primary game(s) and the secondary

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game(s) may comprise any suitable games and/or wagering games, such as, but not limited to: electro-mechanical or video slot or spinning reel type games; video card games such as video draw poker, multi-hand video draw poker, other video poker games, video blackjack games, and video baccarat games; video keno games; video bingo games; and video selection games.

In certain embodiments in which the primary game is a slot or spinning reel type game, the gaming system includes one or more reels in either an electromechanical form with mechanical rotating reels or in a video form with simulated reels and movement thereof. Each reel displays a plurality of indicia or symbols, such as bells, hearts, fruits, numbers, letters, bars, or other images that typically correspond to a theme associated with the gaming system. In certain such embodiments, the gaming system includes one or more paylines associated with the reels. The example EGM 2000b shown in FIG. 4B includes a payline 2152 and a plurality of reels 2154. In certain embodiments, one or more of the reels are independent reels or unisymbol reels. In such embodiments, each independent reel generates and displays one symbol.

In various embodiments, one or more of the paylines is horizontal, vertical, circular, diagonal, angled, or any suitable combination thereof. In other embodiments, each of one or more of the paylines is associated with a plurality of adjacent symbol display areas on a requisite number of adjacent reels. In one such embodiment, one or more paylines are formed between at least two symbol display areas that are adjacent to each other by either sharing a common side or sharing a common corner (i.e., such paylines are connected paylines). The gaming system enables a wager to be placed on one or more of such paylines to activate such paylines. In other embodiments in which one or more paylines are formed between at least two adjacent symbol display areas, the gaming system enables a wager to be placed on a plurality of symbol display areas, which activates those symbol display areas.

In various embodiments, the gaming system provides one or more awards after a spin of the reels when specified types and/or configurations of the indicia or symbols on the reels occur on an active payline or otherwise occur in a winning pattern, occur on the requisite number of adjacent reels, and/or occur in a scatter pay arrangement.

In certain embodiments, the gaming system employs a ways to win award determination. In these embodiments, any outcome to be provided is determined based on a number of associated symbols that are generated in active symbol display areas on the requisite number of adjacent reels (i.e., not on paylines passing through any displayed winning symbol combinations). If a winning symbol combination is generated on the reels, one award for that occurrence of the generated winning symbol combination is provided. Examples of ways to win award determinations are described in U.S. Pat. No. 8,012,011, entitled “Gaming Device and Method Having Independent Reels and Multiple Ways of Winning”; U.S. Pat. No. 8,241,104, entitled “Gaming Device and Method Having Designated Rules for Determining Ways To Win”; and U.S. Pat. No. 8,430,739, entitled “Gaming System and Method Having Wager Dependent Different Symbol Evaluations”.

In various embodiments, the gaming system includes a progressive award. Typically, a progressive award includes an initial amount and an additional amount funded through a portion of each wager placed to initiate a play of a primary game. When one or more triggering events occurs, the gaming system provides at least a portion of the progressive

award. After the gaming system provides the progressive award, an amount of the progressive award is reset to the initial amount and a portion of each subsequent wager is allocated to the next progressive award. Examples of progressive gaming systems are described in U.S. Pat. No. 7,585,223, entitled "Server Based Gaming System Having Multiple Progressive Awards"; U.S. Pat. No. 7,651,392, entitled "Gaming Device System Having Partial Progressive Payout"; U.S. Pat. No. 7,666,093, entitled "Gaming Method and Device Involving Progressive Wagers"; U.S. Pat. No. 7,780,523, entitled "Server Based Gaming System Having Multiple Progressive Awards"; and U.S. Pat. No. 8,337,298, entitled "Gaming Device Having Multiple Different Types of Progressive Awards".

As generally noted above, in addition to providing winning credits or other awards for one or more plays of the primary game(s), in various embodiments the gaming system provides credits or other awards for one or more plays of one or more secondary games. The secondary game typically enables an award to be obtained addition to any award obtained through play of the primary game(s). The secondary game(s) typically produces a higher level of player excitement than the primary game(s) because the secondary game(s) provides a greater expectation of winning than the primary game(s) and is accompanied with more attractive or unusual features than the primary game(s). The secondary game(s) may be any type of suitable game, either similar to or completely different from the primary game.

In various embodiments, the gaming system automatically provides or initiates the secondary game upon the occurrence of a triggering event or the satisfaction of a qualifying condition. In other embodiments, the gaming system initiates the secondary game upon the occurrence of the triggering event or the satisfaction of the qualifying condition and upon receipt of an initiation input. In certain embodiments, the triggering event or qualifying condition is a selected outcome in the primary game(s) or a particular arrangement of one or more indicia on a display device for a play of the primary game(s), such as a "BONUS" symbol appearing on three adjacent reels along a payline following a spin of the reels for a play of the primary game. In other embodiments, the triggering event or qualifying condition occurs based on a certain amount of game play (such as number of games, number of credits, amount of time) being exceeded, or based on a specified number of points being earned during game play. Any suitable triggering event or qualifying condition or any suitable combination of a plurality of different triggering events or qualifying conditions may be employed.

In other embodiments, at least one processor of the gaming system randomly determines when to provide one or more plays of one or more secondary games. In one such embodiment, no apparent reason is provided for providing the secondary game. In this embodiment, qualifying for a secondary game is not triggered by the occurrence of an event in any primary game or based specifically on any of the plays of any primary game. That is, qualification is provided without any explanation or, alternatively, with a simple explanation. In another such embodiment, the gaming system determines qualification for a secondary game at least partially based on a game triggered or symbol triggered event, such as at least partially based on play of a primary game.

In various embodiments, after qualification for a secondary game has been determined, the secondary game participation may be enhanced through continued play on the

primary game. Thus, in certain embodiments, for each secondary game qualifying event, such as a secondary game symbol, that is obtained, a given number of secondary game wagering points or credits is accumulated in a "secondary game meter" configured to accrue the secondary game wagering credits or entries toward eventual participation in the secondary game. In one such embodiment, the occurrence of multiple such secondary game qualifying events in the primary game results in an arithmetic or exponential increase in the number of secondary game wagering credits awarded. In another such embodiment, any extra secondary game wagering credits may be redeemed during the secondary game to extend play of the secondary game.

In certain embodiments, no separate entry fee or buy-in for the secondary game is required. That is, entry into the secondary game cannot be purchased; rather, in these embodiments entry must be won or earned through play of the primary game, thereby encouraging play of the primary game. In other embodiments, qualification for the secondary game is accomplished through a simple "buy-in." For example, qualification through other specified activities is unsuccessful, payment of a fee or placement of an additional wager "buys-in" to the secondary game. In certain embodiments, a separate side wager must be placed on the secondary game or a wager of a designated amount must be placed on the primary game to enable qualification for the secondary game. In these embodiments, the secondary game triggering event must occur and the side wager (or designated primary game wager amount) must have been placed for the secondary game to trigger.

In various embodiments in which the gaming system includes a plurality of EGMs, the EGMs are configured to communicate with one another to provide a group gaming environment. In certain such embodiments, the EGMs enable players of those EGMs to work in conjunction with one another, such as by enabling the players to play together as a team or group, to win one or more awards. In other such embodiments, the EGMs enable players of those EGMs to compete against one another for one or more awards. In one such embodiment, the EGMs enable the players of those EGMs to participate in one or more gaming tournaments for one or more awards. Examples of group gaming systems are described in U.S. Pat. No. 8,070,583, entitled "Server Based Gaming System and Method for Selectively Providing One or More Different Tournaments"; U.S. Pat. No. 8,500,548, entitled "Gaming System and Method for Providing Team Progressive Awards"; and U.S. Pat. No. 8,562,423, entitled "Method and Apparatus for Rewarding Multiple Game Players for a Single Win".

In various embodiments, the gaming system includes one or more player tracking systems. Such player tracking systems enable operators of the gaming system (such as casinos or other gaming establishments) to recognize the value of customer loyalty by identifying frequent customers and rewarding them for their patronage. Such a player tracking system is configured to track a player's gaming activity. In one such embodiment, the player tracking system does so through the use of player tracking cards. In this embodiment, a player is issued a player identification card that has an encoded player identification number that uniquely identifies the player. When the player's playing tracking card is inserted into a card reader of the gaming system to begin a gaming session, the card reader reads the player identification number off the player tracking card to identify the player. The gaming system timely tracks any suitable information or data relating to the identified player's gaming session. The gaming system also timely tracks when

the player tracking card is removed to conclude play for that gaming session. In another embodiment, rather than requiring insertion of a player tracking card into the card reader, the gaming system utilizes one or more portable devices, such as a mobile phone, a radio frequency identification tag, or any other suitable wireless device, to track when a gaming session begins and ends. In another embodiment, the gaming system utilizes any suitable biometric technology or ticket technology to track when a gaming session begins and ends.

In such embodiments, during one or more gaming sessions, the gaming system tracks any suitable information or data, such as any amounts wagered, average wager amounts, and/or the time at which these wagers are placed. In different embodiments, for one or more players, the player tracking system includes the player's account number, the player's card number, the player's first name, the player's surname, the player's preferred name, the player's player tracking ranking, any promotion status associated with the player's player tracking card, the player's address, the player's birthday, the player's anniversary, the player's recent gaming sessions, or any other suitable data. In various embodiments, such tracked information and/or any suitable feature associated with the player tracking system is displayed on a player tracking display. In various embodiments, such tracked information and/or any suitable feature associated with the player tracking system is displayed via one or more service windows that are displayed on the central display device and/or the upper display device. Examples of player tracking systems are described in U.S. Pat. No. 6,722,985, entitled "Universal Player Tracking System"; U.S. Pat. No. 6,908,387, entitled "Player Tracking Communication Mechanisms in a Gaming Machine"; U.S. Pat. No. 7,311,605, entitled "Player Tracking Assembly for Complete Patron Tracking for Both Gaming and Non-Gaming Casino Activity"; U.S. Pat. No. 7,611,411, entitled "Player Tracking Instruments Having Multiple Communication Modes"; U.S. Pat. No. 7,617,151, entitled "Alternative Player Tracking Techniques"; and U.S. Pat. No. 8,057,298, entitled "Virtual Player Tracking and Related Services".

Web-Based Gaming

In various embodiments, the gaming system includes one or more servers configured to communicate with a personal gaming device—such as a smartphone, a tablet computer, a desktop computer, or a laptop computer—to enable web-based game play using the personal gaming device. In various embodiments, the player must first access a gaming website via an Internet browser of the personal gaming device or execute an application (commonly called an "app") installed on the personal gaming device before the player can use the personal gaming device to participate in web-based game play. In certain embodiments, the one or more servers and the personal gaming device operate in a thin-client environment. In these embodiments, the personal gaming device receives inputs via one or more input devices (such as a touch screen and/or physical buttons), the personal gaming device sends the received inputs to the one or more servers, the one or more servers make various determinations based on the inputs and determine content to be displayed (such as a randomly determined game outcome and corresponding award), the one or more servers send the content to the personal gaming device, and the personal gaming device displays the content.

In certain such embodiments, the one or more servers must identify the player before enabling game play on the personal gaming device (or, in some embodiments, before

enabling monetary wager-based game play on the personal gaming device). In these embodiments, the player must identify herself to the one or more servers, such as by inputting the player's unique playername and password combination, providing an input to a biometric sensor (e.g., a fingerprint sensor, a retinal sensor, a voice sensor, or a facial-recognition sensor), or providing any other suitable information.

Once identified, the one or more servers enable the player to establish an account balance from which the player can draw credits usable to wager on plays of a game. In certain embodiments, the one or more servers enable the player to initiate an electronic funds transfer to transfer funds from a bank account to the player's account balance. In other embodiments, the one or more servers enable the player to make a payment using the player's credit card, debit card, or other suitable device to add money to the player's account balance. In other embodiments, the one or more servers enable the player to add money to the player's account balance via a peer-to-peer type application, such as PayPal or Venmo. The one or more servers also enable the player to cash out the player's account balance (or part of it) in any suitable manner, such as via an electronic funds transfer, by initiating creation of a paper check that is mailed to the player, or by initiating printing of a voucher at a kiosk in a gaming establishment.

In certain embodiments, the one or more servers include a payment server that handles establishing and cashing out players' account balances and a separate game server configured to determine the outcome and any associated award for a play of a game. In these embodiments, the game server is configured to communicate with the personal gaming device and the payment device, and the personal gaming device and the payment device are not configured to directly communicate with one another. In these embodiments, when the game server receives data representing a request to start a play of a game at a desired wager, the game server sends data representing the desired wager to the payment server. The payment server determines whether the player's account balance can cover the desired wager (i.e., includes a monetary balance at least equal to the desired wager).

If the payment server determines that the player's account balance cannot cover the desired wager, the payment server notifies the game server, which then instructs the personal gaming device to display a suitable notification to the player that the player's account balance is too low to place the desired wager. If the payment server determines that the player's account balance can cover the desired wager, the payment server deducts the desired wager from the account balance and notifies the game server. The game server then determines an outcome and any associated award for the play of the game. The game server notifies the payment server of any nonzero award, and the payment server increases the player's account balance by the nonzero award. The game server sends data representing the outcome and any award to the personal gaming device, which displays the outcome and any award.

In certain embodiments, the one or more servers enable web-based game play using a personal gaming device only if the personal gaming device satisfies one or more jurisdictional requirements. In one embodiment, the one or more servers enable web-based game play using the personal gaming device only if the personal gaming device is located within a designated geographic area (such as within certain state or county lines or within the boundaries of a gaming establishment). In this embodiment, the geolocation module of the personal gaming device determines the location of the

personal gaming device and sends the location to the one or more servers, which determine whether the personal gaming device is located within the designated geographic area. In various embodiments, the one or more servers enable non-monetary wager-based game play if the personal gaming device is located outside of the designated geographic area.

In various embodiments, the gaming system includes an EGM configured to communicate with a personal gaming device—such as a smartphone, a tablet computer, a desktop computer, or a laptop computer—to enable tethered mobile game play using the personal gaming device. Generally, in these embodiments, the EGM establishes communication with the personal gaming device and enables the player to play games on the EGM remotely via the personal gaming device. In certain embodiments, the gaming system includes a geo-fence system that enables tethered game play within a particular geographic area but not outside of that geographic area. Examples of tethering an EGM to a personal gaming device and geo-fencing are described in U.S. Patent Appl. Pub. No. 2013/0267324, entitled “Remote Gaming Method Allowing Temporary Inactivation Without Terminating Playing Session Due to Game Inactivity”.

Social Network Integration

In certain embodiments, the gaming system is configured to communicate with a social network server that hosts or partially hosts a social networking website via a data network (such as the Internet) to integrate a player's gaming experience with the player's social networking account. This enables the gaming system to send certain information to the social network server that the social network server can use to create content (such as text, an image, and/or a video) and post it to the player's wall, newsfeed, or similar area of the social networking website accessible by the player's connections (and in certain cases the public) such that the player's connections can view that information. This also enables the gaming system to receive certain information from the social network server, such as the player's likes or dislikes or the player's list of connections. In certain embodiments, the gaming system enables the player to link the player's player account to the player's social networking account(s). This enables the gaming system to, once it identifies the player and initiates a gaming session (such as via the player logging in to a website (or an application) on the player's personal gaming device or via the player inserting the player's player tracking card into an EGM), link that gaming session to the player's social networking account(s). In other embodiments, the gaming system enables the player to link the player's social networking account(s) to individual gaming sessions when desired by providing the required login information.

For instance, in one embodiment, if a player wins a particular award (e.g., a progressive award or a jackpot award) or an award that exceeds a certain threshold (e.g., an award exceeding \$1,000), the gaming system sends information about the award to the social network server to enable the server to create associated content (such as a screenshot of the outcome and associated award) and to post that content to the player's wall (or other suitable area) of the social networking website for the player's connections to see (and to entice them to play). In another embodiment, if a player joins a multiplayer game and there is another seat available, the gaming system sends that information to the social network sever to enable the server to create associated content (such as text indicating a vacancy for that particular game) and to post that content to the player's wall (or other

suitable area) of the social networking website for the player's connections to see (and to entice them to fill the vacancy). In another embodiment, if the player consents, the gaming system sends advertisement information or offer information to the social network server to enable the social network server to create associated content (such as text or an image reflecting an advertisement and/or an offer) and to post that content to the player's wall (or other suitable area) of the social networking website for the player's connections to see. In another embodiment, the gaming system enables the player to recommend a game to the player's connections by posting a recommendation to the player's wall (or other suitable area) of the social networking website.

Differentiating Certain Gaming Systems from General Purpose Computing Devices

Certain of the gaming systems described herein, such as EGMs located in a casino or another gaming establishment, include certain components and/or are configured to operate in certain manners that differentiate these systems from general purpose computing devices, i.e., certain personal gaming devices such as desktop computers and laptop computers.

For instance, EGMs are highly regulated to ensure fairness and, in many cases, EGMs are configured to award monetary awards up to multiple millions of dollars. To satisfy security and regulatory requirements in a gaming environment, hardware and/or software architectures are implemented in EGMs that differ significantly from those of general purpose computing devices. For purposes of illustration, a description of EGMs relative to general purpose computing devices and some examples of these additional (or different) hardware and/or software architectures found in EGMs are described below.

At first glance, one might think that adapting general purpose computing device technologies to the gaming industry and EGMs would be a simple proposition because both general purpose computing devices and EGMs employ processors that control a variety of devices. However, due to at least: (1) the regulatory requirements placed on EGMs, (2) the harsh environment in which EGMs operate, (3) security requirements, and (4) fault tolerance requirements, adapting general purpose computing device technologies to EGMs can be quite difficult. Further, techniques and methods for solving a problem in the general purpose computing device industry, such as device compatibility and connectivity issues, might not be adequate in the gaming industry. For instance, a fault or a weakness tolerated in a general purpose computing device, such as security holes in software or frequent crashes, is not tolerated in an EGM because in an EGM these faults can lead to a direct loss of funds from the EGM, such as stolen cash or loss of revenue when the EGM is not operating properly or when the random outcome determination is manipulated.

Certain differences between general purpose computing devices and EGMs are described below. A first difference between EGMs and general purpose computing devices is that EGMs are state-based systems. A state-based system stores and maintains its current state in a non-volatile memory such that, in the event of a power failure or other malfunction, the state-based system can return to that state when the power is restored or the malfunction is remedied. For instance, for a state-based EGM, if the EGM displays an award for a game of chance but the power to the EGM fails before the EGM provides the award to the player, the EGM stores the pre-power failure state in a non-volatile memory,

returns to that state upon restoration of power, and provides the award to the player. This requirement affects the software and hardware design on EGMs. General purpose computing devices are not state-based machines, and a majority of data is usually lost when a malfunction occurs on a general purpose computing device.

A second difference between EGMs and general purpose computing devices is that, for regulatory purposes, the software on the EGM utilized to operate the EGM has been designed to be static and monolithic to prevent cheating by the operator of the EGM. For instance, one solution that has been employed in the gaming industry to prevent cheating and to satisfy regulatory requirements has been to manufacture an EGM that can use a proprietary processor running instructions to provide the game of chance from an EPROM or other form of non-volatile memory. The coding instructions on the EPROM are static (non-changeable) and must be approved by a gaming regulators in a particular jurisdiction and installed in the presence of a person representing the gaming jurisdiction. Any changes to any part of the software required to generate the game of chance, such as adding a new device driver used to operate a device during generation of the game of chance, can require burning a new EPROM approved by the gaming jurisdiction and reinstalling the new EPROM on the EGM in the presence of a gaming regulator. Regardless of whether the EPROM solution is used, to gain approval in most gaming jurisdictions, an EGM must demonstrate sufficient safeguards that prevent an operator or a player of an EGM from manipulating the EGM's hardware and software in a manner that gives him an unfair, and in some cases illegal, advantage.

A third difference between EGMs and general purpose computing devices is authentication—EGMs storing code are configured to authenticate the code to determine if the code is unaltered before executing the code. If the code has been altered, the EGM prevents the code from being executed. The code authentication requirements in the gaming industry affect both hardware and software designs on EGMs. Certain EGMs use hash functions to authenticate code. For instance, one EGM stores game program code, a hash function, and an authentication hash (which may be encrypted). Before executing the game program code, the EGM hashes the game program code using the hash function to obtain a result hash and compares the result hash to the authentication hash. If the result hash matches the authentication hash, the EGM determines that the game program code is valid and executes the game program code. If the result hash does not match the authentication hash, the EGM determines that the game program code has been altered (i.e., may have been tampered with) and prevents execution of the game program code. Examples of EGM code authentication are described in U.S. Pat. No. 6,962,530, entitled "Authentication in a Secure Computerized Gaming System"; U.S. Pat. No. 7,043,641, entitled "Encryption in a Secure Computerized Gaming System"; U.S. Pat. No. 7,201,662, entitled "Method and Apparatus for Software Authentication"; and U.S. Pat. No. 8,627,097, entitled "System and Method Enabling Parallel Processing of Hash Functions Using Authentication Checkpoint Hashes".

A fourth difference between EGMs and general purpose computing devices is that EGMs have unique peripheral device requirements that differ from those of a general purpose computing device, such as peripheral device security requirements not usually addressed by general purpose computing devices. For instance, monetary devices, such as coin dispensers, bill validators, and ticket printers and computing devices that are used to govern the input and

output of cash or other items having monetary value (such as tickets) to and from an EGM have security requirements that are not typically addressed in general purpose computing devices. Therefore, many general purpose computing device techniques and methods developed to facilitate device connectivity and device compatibility do not address the emphasis placed on security in the gaming industry.

To address some of the issues described above, a number of hardware/software components and architectures are utilized in EGMs that are not typically found in general purpose computing devices. These hardware/software components and architectures, as described below in more detail, include but are not limited to watchdog timers, voltage monitoring systems, state-based software architecture and supporting hardware, specialized communication interfaces, security monitoring, and trusted memory.

Certain EGMs use a watchdog timer to provide a software failure detection mechanism. In a normally-operating EGM, the operating software periodically accesses control registers in the watchdog timer subsystem to "re-trigger" the watchdog. Should the operating software fail to access the control registers within a preset timeframe, the watchdog timer will timeout and generate a system reset. Typical watchdog timer circuits include a loadable timeout counter register to enable the operating software to set the timeout interval within a certain range of time. A differentiating feature of some circuits is that the operating software cannot completely disable the function of the watchdog timer. In other words, the watchdog timer always functions from the time power is applied to the board.

Certain EGMs use several power supply voltages to operate portions of the computer circuitry. These can be generated in a central power supply or locally on the computer board. If any of these voltages falls out of the tolerance limits of the circuitry they power, unpredictable operation of the EGM may result. Though most modern general purpose computing devices include voltage monitoring circuitry, these types of circuits only report voltage status to the operating software. Out of tolerance voltages can cause software malfunction, creating a potential uncontrolled condition in the general purpose computing device. Certain EGMs have power supplies with relatively tighter voltage margins than that required by the operating circuitry. In addition, the voltage monitoring circuitry implemented in certain EGMs typically has two thresholds of control. The first threshold generates a software event that can be detected by the operating software and an error condition then generated. This threshold is triggered when a power supply voltage falls out of the tolerance range of the power supply, but is still within the operating range of the circuitry. The second threshold is set when a power supply voltage falls out of the operating tolerance of the circuitry. In this case, the circuitry generates a reset, halting operation of the EGM.

As described above, certain EGMs are state-based machines. Different functions of the game provided by the EGM (e.g., bet, play, result, points in the graphical presentation, etc.) may be defined as a state. When the EGM moves a game from one state to another, the EGM stores critical data regarding the game software in a custom non-volatile memory subsystem. This ensures that the player's wager and credits are preserved and to minimize potential disputes in the event of a malfunction on the EGM. In general, the EGM does not advance from a first state to a second state until critical information that enables the first state to be reconstructed has been stored. This feature enables the EGM to recover operation to the current state of play in the event of

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a malfunction, loss of power, etc. that occurred just before the malfunction. In at least one embodiment, the EGM is configured to store such critical information using atomic transactions.

Generally, an atomic operation in computer science refers to a set of operations that can be combined so that they appear to the rest of the gaming system to be a single operation with only two possible outcomes: success or failure. As related to data storage, an atomic transaction may be characterized as series of database operations which either all occur, or all do not occur. A guarantee of atomicity prevents updates to the database occurring only partially, which can result in data corruption.

To ensure the success of atomic transactions relating to critical information to be stored in the EGM memory before a failure event (e.g., malfunction, loss of power, etc.), memory that includes one or more of the following criteria be used: direct memory access capability; data read/write capability which meets or exceeds minimum read/write access characteristics (such as at least 5.08 Mbytes/sec (Read) and/or at least 38.0 Mbytes/sec (Write)). Memory devices that meet or exceed the above criteria may be referred to as "fault-tolerant" memory devices.

Typically, battery-backed RAM devices may be configured to function as fault-tolerant devices according to the above criteria, whereas flash RAM and/or disk drive memory are typically not configurable to function as fault-tolerant devices according to the above criteria. Accordingly, battery-backed RAM devices are typically used to preserve EGM critical data, although other types of non-volatile memory devices may be employed. These memory devices are typically not used in typical general purpose computing devices.

Thus, in at least one embodiment, the EGM is configured to store critical information in fault-tolerant memory (e.g., battery-backed RAM devices) using atomic transactions. Further, in at least one embodiment, the fault-tolerant memory is able to successfully complete all desired atomic transactions (e.g., relating to the storage of EGM critical information) within a time period of 200 milliseconds or less. In at least one embodiment, the time period of 200 milliseconds represents a maximum amount of time for which sufficient power may be available to the various EGM components after a power outage event has occurred at the EGM.

As described previously, the EGM may not advance from a first state to a second state until critical information that enables the first state to be reconstructed has been atomically stored. After the state of the EGM is restored during the play of a game of chance, game play may resume and the game may be completed in a manner that is no different than if the malfunction had not occurred. Thus, for example, when a malfunction occurs during a game of chance, the EGM may be restored to a state in the game of chance just before when the malfunction occurred. The restored state may include metering information and graphical information that was displayed on the EGM in the state before the malfunction. For example, when the malfunction occurs during the play of a card game after the cards have been dealt, the EGM may be restored with the cards that were previously displayed as part of the card game. As another example, a bonus game may be triggered during the play of a game of chance in which a player is required to make a number of selections on a video display screen. When a malfunction has occurred after the player has made one or more selections, the EGM may be restored to a state that shows the graphical presentation just before the malfunction including an indication of

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selections that have already been made by the player. In general, the EGM may be restored to any state in a plurality of states that occur in the game of chance that occurs while the game of chance is played or to states that occur between the play of a game of chance.

Game history information regarding previous games played such as an amount wagered, the outcome of the game, and the like may also be stored in a non-volatile memory device. The information stored in the non-volatile memory may be detailed enough to reconstruct a portion of the graphical presentation that was previously presented on the EGM and the state of the EGM (e.g., credits) at the time the game of chance was played. The game history information may be utilized in the event of a dispute. For example, a player may decide that in a previous game of chance that they did not receive credit for an award that they believed they won. The game history information may be used to reconstruct the state of the EGM before, during, and/or after the disputed game to demonstrate whether the player was correct or not in the player's assertion. Examples of a state-based EGM, recovery from malfunctions, and game history are described in U.S. Pat. No. 6,804,763, entitled "High Performance Battery Backed RAM Interface"; U.S. Pat. No. 6,863,608, entitled "Frame Capture of Actual Game Play"; U.S. Pat. No. 7,111,141, entitled "Dynamic NV-RAM"; and U.S. Pat. No. 7,384,339, entitled, "Frame Capture of Actual Game Play".

Another feature of EGMs is that they often include unique interfaces, including serial interfaces, to connect to specific subsystems internal and external to the EGM. The serial devices may have electrical interface requirements that differ from the "standard" EIA serial interfaces provided by general purpose computing devices. These interfaces may include, for example, Fiber Optic Serial, optically coupled serial interfaces, current loop style serial interfaces, etc. In addition, to conserve serial interfaces internally in the EGM, serial devices may be connected in a shared, daisy-chain fashion in which multiple peripheral devices are connected to a single serial channel.

The serial interfaces may be used to transmit information using communication protocols that are unique to the gaming industry. For example, IGT's Netplex is a proprietary communication protocol used for serial communication between EGMs. As another example, SAS is a communication protocol used to transmit information, such as metering information, from an EGM to a remote device. Often SAS is used in conjunction with a player tracking system.

Certain EGMs may alternatively be treated as peripheral devices to a casino communication controller and connected in a shared daisy chain fashion to a single serial interface. In both cases, the peripheral devices are assigned device addresses. If so, the serial controller circuitry must implement a method to generate or detect unique device addresses. General purpose computing device serial ports are not able to do this.

Security monitoring circuits detect intrusion into an EGM by monitoring security switches attached to access doors in the EGM cabinet. Access violations result in suspension of game play and can trigger additional security operations to preserve the current state of game play. These circuits also function when power is off by use of a battery backup. In power-off operation, these circuits continue to monitor the access doors of the EGM. When power is restored, the EGM can determine whether any security violations occurred while power was off, e.g., via software for reading status registers. This can trigger event log entries and further data authentication operations by the EGM software.

Trusted memory devices and/or trusted memory sources are included in an EGM to ensure the authenticity of the software that may be stored on less secure memory subsystems, such as mass storage devices. Trusted memory devices and controlling circuitry are typically designed to not enable modification of the code and data stored in the memory device while the memory device is installed in the EGM. The code and data stored in these devices may include authentication algorithms, random number generators, authentication keys, operating system kernels, etc. The purpose of these trusted memory devices is to provide gaming regulatory authorities a root trusted authority within the computing environment of the EGM that can be tracked and verified as original. This may be accomplished via removal of the trusted memory device from the EGM computer and verification of the secure memory device contents is a separate third party verification device. Once the trusted memory device is verified as authentic, and based on the approval of the verification algorithms included in the trusted device, the EGM is enabled to verify the authenticity of additional code and data that may be located in the gaming computer assembly, such as code and data stored on hard disk drives. Examples of trusted memory devices are described in U.S. Pat. No. 6,685,567, entitled "Process Verification".

In at least one embodiment, at least a portion of the trusted memory devices/sources may correspond to memory that cannot easily be altered (e.g., "unalterable memory") such as EPROMS, PROMS, Bios, Extended Bios, and/or other memory sources that are able to be configured, verified, and/or authenticated (e.g., for authenticity) in a secure and controlled manner.

According to one embodiment, when a trusted information source is in communication with a remote device via a network, the remote device may employ a verification scheme to verify the identity of the trusted information source. For example, the trusted information source and the remote device may exchange information using public and private encryption keys to verify each other's identities. In another embodiment, the remote device and the trusted information source may engage in methods using zero knowledge proofs to authenticate each of their respective identities.

EGMs storing trusted information may utilize apparatuses or methods to detect and prevent tampering. For instance, trusted information stored in a trusted memory device may be encrypted to prevent its misuse. In addition, the trusted memory device may be secured behind a locked door. Further, one or more sensors may be coupled to the memory device to detect tampering with the memory device and provide some record of the tampering. In yet another example, the memory device storing trusted information might be designed to detect tampering attempts and clear or erase itself when an attempt at tampering has been detected. Examples of trusted memory devices/sources are described in U.S. Pat. No. 7,515,718, entitled "Secured Virtual Network in a Gaming Environment".

Mass storage devices used in a general purpose computing devices typically enable code and data to be read from and written to the mass storage device. In a gaming environment, modification of the gaming code stored on a mass storage device is strictly controlled and would only be enabled under specific maintenance type events with electronic and physical enablers required. Though this level of security could be provided by software, EGMs that include mass storage devices include hardware level mass storage data protection circuitry that operates at the circuit level to

monitor attempts to modify data on the mass storage device and will generate both software and hardware error triggers should a data modification be attempted without the proper electronic and physical enablers being present. Examples of using a mass storage device are described in U.S. Pat. No. 6,149,522, entitled "Method of Authenticating Game Data Sets in an Electronic Casino Gaming System".

It should be appreciated that the terminology used herein is for the purpose of describing particular aspects only and is not intended to be limiting of the disclosure. For example, the singular forms "a", "an" and "the" are intended to include the plural forms as well, unless the context clearly indicates otherwise. In another example, the terms "including" and "comprising" and variations thereof, when used in this specification, specify the presence of stated features, steps, operations, elements, and/or components, but do not preclude the presence or addition of one or more other features, steps, operations, elements, components, and/or groups thereof. Additionally, a listing of items does not imply that any or all of the items are mutually exclusive nor does a listing of items imply that any or all of the items are collectively exhaustive of anything or in a particular order, unless expressly specified otherwise. Moreover, as used herein, the term "and/or" includes any and all combinations of one or more of the associated listed items. It should be further appreciated that headings of sections provided in this document and the title are for convenience only, and are not to be taken as limiting the disclosure in any way. Furthermore, unless expressly specified otherwise, devices that are in communication with each other need not be in continuous communication with each other and may communicate directly or indirectly through one or more intermediaries.

Various changes and modifications to the present embodiments described herein will be apparent to those skilled in the art. For example, a description of an embodiment with several components in communication with each other does not imply that all such components are required, or that each of the disclosed components must communicate with every other component. On the contrary a variety of optional components are described to illustrate the wide variety of possible embodiments of the present disclosure. As such, these changes and modifications can be made without departing from the spirit and scope of the present subject matter and without diminishing its intended technical scope. It is therefore intended that such changes and modifications be covered by the appended claims.

The invention claimed is:

1. A system comprising:

a processor; and

a memory device that stores a plurality of instructions that, when executed by the processor, cause the processor to:

receive data associated with a social media content distribution event associated with a distribution of social media content on a social media site, wherein the social media content distribution event occurred in association with a game outcome determined for a play of a game which was displayed by a first display device, and

communicate data that results in a display, by a quantity of second display devices associated with a land-based gaming establishment and different from the first display device, of the social media content for a predetermined period of time, wherein at least one of a determination of a duration of the predetermined period of time is based on the occurrence of the social media content distribution event associated

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with the game outcome with different occurrences of social media content distribution events associated with different game outcomes resulting in different durations of the predetermined period of time and a determination of the quantity of second display devices is based on the occurrence of the social media content distribution event associated with the game outcome with different occurrences of social media content distribution events associated with different game outcomes resulting in different quantities of second display devices.

2. The system of claim 1, wherein the quantity of second display devices comprises a plurality of display devices associated with the land-based gaming establishment.

3. The system of claim 1, wherein the social media content comprises any of a first social media content component associated with the play of the game, and a second social media content component associated with an activity occurring at a land-based gaming establishment that is independent of any play of any game.

4. The system of claim 3, wherein any of the first social media content component and the second social media content component comprises any of: a still image, a video clip, a sound clip, an audio-visual clip, text, transaction information, location information, application usage information, event attendance information, and biometric information.

5. The system of claim 1, wherein the predetermined period of time comprises a first duration responsive to the social media content distribution event occurring in association with a first player and the predetermined period of time comprises a second, different duration responsive to the social media content distribution event occurring in association with a second, different player.

6. The system of claim 1, wherein the predetermined period of time comprises a first duration responsive to the social media content distribution event occurring in association with a first game outcome determined for the play of the game and the predetermined period of time comprises a second, different duration responsive to the social media content distribution event occurring in association with a second, different game outcome determined for the play of the game.

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7. The system of claim 1, wherein the predetermined period of time comprises a first duration responsive to the social media content distribution event occurring in association with first social media content and the predetermined period of time comprises a second, different duration responsive to the social media content distribution event occurring in association with second, different social media content.

8. The system of claim 1, wherein the memory device comprises a plurality of further instructions that, when executed by the processor responsive to the receipt of data associated with the game outcome, cause the processor to determine the social media content.

9. The system of claim 1, wherein the social media content is in addition to any award associated with the game outcome.

10. A gaming system comprising:

a processor; and

a memory device that stores a plurality of instructions that, when executed by the processor for a play of a game, cause the processor to:

determine a game outcome,

communicate data that results in a display, by a display device, of the determined game outcome,

responsive to an election stored in association with an account of a user to activate a social media award feature, without determining any monetary award associated with the determined game outcome, determine a non-monetary award associated with the determined game outcome, the non-monetary award being associated with a distribution of social media content on a social media site, and

responsive to no election stored in association with any account of the user to activate the social media award feature:

without determining any non-monetary award associated with the determined game outcome, determine a monetary award associated with the determined game outcome, the monetary award being independent of any non-monetary award associated with any distribution of any social media content on any social media site, and

communicate data that results in a display, by the display device, of the determined monetary award.

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